INDEPENDENT, ALTERNATIVE, AND COMMUNITY MEDIA AN OPEN READER

Edited and with an introduction by
David W. Park & Meghan Grosse

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Independent, Alternative, and Community Media: An Open Reader

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CHAPTER 40

Conventions, Computers, and Collective Action (1991–2007)

Francesca Coppa

In *Vidding: A History* (University of Michigan Press, 2022).

Vidding as a fandom in itself—by which I mean vidding not just as a tool used to express love for some other story world or universe but also as an art form with its own developmental trajectory, canon of influential work, and critical language—was codified in and around two fan conventions: Escapade (1991–) and Vividcon (2002–18). The heyday of these two conventions coincides with fandom's rapid expansion onto the Internet. As early adopters of technology, media fans organized online in the early 1990s on Usenet and in IRC; on topic-specific mailing lists, on web rings, forums, and blogs; and eventually on the nascent social networks. Analog media and distribution methods were supplanted by their digital counterparts as letterzines gave way to e-mail lists and discussion forums, and as fanfiction zines were superseded by online archives. However, vidding remained primarily analog through the 1990s and an off-line phenomenon well into the aughts. For most fans during those years, seeing new vids meant physically going to where vids were shown; secondarily, it might mean getting a nonattending membership at a convention with a vid show and having them mail you a VHS tape or DVD of premiering vids.

But conventions were where the conversations were happening and where an artistic community—contentious, invested—was forming. Fans came together annually in places like Santa Barbara, Los Angeles, and Chicago to watch vids—and talk about them. These conventions became a place not only to hammer out a language for articulating different vidding aesthetics (and thus a kind of grassroots film school) but also to provide a context within which fans could collectively grapple with the technological, legal, and political issues

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of the digital revolution. These included the practical problems having to do with creating and sharing vids in the digital age, like building sufficiently powerful computers; learning new software; obtaining footage; getting online; and negotiating the advantages and disadvantages of different modes of digital distribution, including their technological difficulty, artistic presentation, and legal terms of service. However, they also included a host of issues that have turned out to be crucial in this brave new digital world: questions of copyright and sampling; of spreadability, context, and artistic control; of privacy, publicity, and pseudonymity; of credit and profit; and of the vast constellation of problems that form the field of what we now call technical ethics.[1]

These issues are part of our current international conversation about the Internet, but fans in general, and vidders in particular, were talking through them years before most people. The vidding community of 1991–2007 was both tightly connected and well informed, and therefore easily mobilized as activists when digital concerns became higher profile in the second half of the aughts. Vidders helped to found the Organization for Transformative Works, the fan advocacy nonprofit that created the Archive of Our Own to house fanfiction, and that has done much political lobbying and other work on behalf of fans and remixers. Vidders also formed coalitions, joining forces with anime vidders, political remixers, vloggers, machinima makers, and others. And vidders organized testimony and collaborated in various ways with Internet advocacy organizations, such as the Electronic Frontier Foundation, Public Knowledge, MediaCommons, Critical Commons, and the Institute for Multimedia Literacy to fight for the digital rights of ordinary people. Vidders were ultimately instrumental in securing the 2009 DMCA exemption for noncommercial remixing, as well as its renewals and expansions in 2012, 2015, and 2018. But all these accomplishments were built on organizational and community work that vidders and other fans had done two decades earlier, starting at a California fan convention called Escapade.

Fan Vidders and Conventions

Escapade: California's Slash Slumber Party

Escapade is a convention dedicated to slash—that is, to creating and enjoying interpretations of pop culture texts that imagine same-sex romance or sexual intimacy between characters. Historically, slash was used to refer almost exclusively to fan works (fiction, art, vids) that foregrounded or created male/male romances (Kirk/Spock, Starsky/ Hutch), at least partly because male characters tended to take center stage[2] in the stories that fans liked, though there were femslash vids featuring pairings like Xena/Gabrielle, Janeway/Seven of Nine, and Buffy/ Faith. Much as MediaWest offered a collective home to fans of many individual sci-

[1] Casey Fiesler, "Tech Ethics Curricula: A Collection of Syllabi," *Medium*, July 5, 2018, https://medium.com/@cfiesler/tech-ethics-curricula-a-collection-of-syllabi-3eedfb76be18

[2] Even today, surprisingly few genre TV shows and movies pass the Bechdel test, the three-part test developed by Alison Bechdel in her comic strip *Dykes to Watch Out For* (1983–2008): whether (1) two (named) female characters (2) talk to each other (3) about something other than a man. *Star Wars*, *Lord of the Rings*, and most of the original Star Trek (TV and movies) fail. Genre TV shows and movies tend either to be buddy-focused (with female characters secondary or absent) or team-focused (where the team is made of a bunch of men and a token woman; hello, Black Widow!).

ence fiction and fantasy media universes, Escapade was an outgrowth of the single-fandom conventions of the 1980s dedicated to slash-heavy fandoms like *Starsky and Hutch* and *Blake's 7*. Founded by slash fans Charlotte C. Hill and Megan Kent, Escapade was designed to appeal to what they saw as a younger, hipper audience. These were fans of particular slash pairings, but they were also fans for whom slash itself was the attraction. For such fans, "slash" was not just a noun but also a verb indicating an interpretive strategy and a shared activity. Being a slasher was thus both an identity and a practice. Slash fans did something active: they slashed the television they watched, creating homoerotic readings that they shared in conversation or through art. Because they watched television with their so-called slash goggles on, we shouldn't be surprised that Escapade became a center for vidding and vid culture. Being a slash fan was already correlated with a particular way of seeing, a distinct and active mode of spectatorship.

Slash fans have had an outsize impact on fandom and on the discourse about fandom. Slash is certainly overrepresented in the scholarly literature, probably because as a phenomenon, women coming together to make homoerotic art seems to demand explanation. But I would argue that slash fans have earned their oversized footprint. They have been unusually productive and innovative, mostly because they were forced to be. The kinds of stories slash fans liked were simply not available in the mass media,[3] so they had to write their own. Then, having written the stories, slash fans had to create an infrastructure to share and distribute them, which required negotiating with other fans' desires not to see queer or erotic material. This was easy enough when it was just a matter of separating gen from slash zines in the dealers' room (slash zines were kept under the table), but things got complicated online, when different kinds of fans were attracted to the same groups, mailing lists, and forums. Fandom's solution was to design and build elaborate tagging systems for their work, creating labels to tell readers what's in the tin. These came into use as story headers and found their apogee in the curated folksonomy of the Archive of Our Own. This metadata has subsequently attracted the attention of computer scientists, librarians, web developers, and other information specialists[4] who admire fandom's organizational creativity. For instance, Maciej Ceglowski, the owner of Pinboard, was surprised when his new bookmarking site was suddenly "filled with slash fiction." However, he eventually concluded, "The fans are all right." Better than all right, in fact; Ceglowski realized that fans

> had constructed an edifice of incredibly elaborate tagging conventions, plugins, and scripts to organize their output along a bewildering number of dimensions. If you wanted to read a 3000 word fic where Picard forces Gandalf into sexual bondage, and it seems unconsensual but secretly both want it, and it's R-explicit but not NC-17 explicit, all you had to do was search along the appropriate combination of tags (and if you couldn't find it, someone would probably write it for you). By 2008 a whole suite of theoretical ideas about folksonomy, crowdsourcing, faceted information retrieval,

[3] Today slash fans have colonized certain parts of the publishing world, but homoerotic fiction remains a relatively niche interest. Moreover, as fans will be quick to point out, we still haven't had a major superhero, detective, starship captain, or Jedi involved in a same-sex romance, though we now have canonical gay characters on *Star Trek: Discovery* (2017–).

[4] See Casey Fiesler, Shannon Morrison, and Amy S. Bruckman, "An Archive of Their Own: A Case Study of Feminist HCI and Values in Design," in *Proceedings of the SIGCHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems (CHI '16)*, 2574–85, https://doi.org/10.1145/2858036.2858409

> collaborative editing and emergent ontology had been implemented by a bunch of friendly people so that they could read about Kirk drilling Spock.[5]

This is the sort of thing that gives slash fandom its reputation: the combination of cheerful female depravity and an unbelievably obsessive commitment to information technology. But slash fans had to work hard to make and distribute the kind of stories they wanted to see. They also had to carve out and defend spaces for themselves, often against the will of more mainstream fans.

For instance, in "Fandom and Male Privilege: Seven Years Later," Rebecca Lucy Busker talks about her experience with the Batman LiveJournal community site Scans_daily in 2005:

> [Scans_daily] had been founded by women fans to be friendly, but not exclusive, to slashy interpretations and discussions of these comics panels and pages. Many of the fans who initially came to post and discuss comics there approached comics as part of their larger media fandom, and also as a part of their larger *slash* fandom. However . . . the community began attracting more mainstream comics fans, whose background was in the broader realms of geekdom, and for whom slash was either unknown or at least a very strange thing (slash being at least slightly less mainstream at the time). Not surprisingly, most of these fans were men. Also perhaps not surprisingly, many of them missed the community information that said "slash-friendly" on the way in.[6]

According to Busker, it wasn't enough that female fans had created this community and let male fans join if they wanted; the men wanted to control (in this case limit) what was talked about. This kind of community building and defense draws people together—another reason why slash fandom is so coherent and organized. Moreover, many slash fans have made long-term commitments to fandom, building projects over many years (archives, challenges, forums) and sticking around to administer or maintain them. Fans of gen aren't confined to fandom the same way. They have the whole commercial art world to choose from.[7]

For these and other reasons, slash fans in general, and the slash fans who congregated around Escapade in particular, have had an outsize impact on fandom, including vidding and vid culture. (This is not even to mention fan studies: Henry Jenkins, Constance Penley,[8] and Camille Bacon-Smith all went to Escapade.) Their collectivity was key. Fans who didn't come to multifannish conventions did not make the same sort of impact, and it's fair to fear that consolidated slash fandom may have run roughshod over or otherwise obscured the work of smaller, less organized, or more marginalized groups of fans. For example, fans of *Xena: Warrior Princess* made VHS vids and showed them at weekly "Xena nights" at Meow Mix,[9] a famous lesbian bar on New York's Lower East Side. Vids were also shown at commercial *Xena* conventions. But most of those vids never made it out of their specific community; they

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[5] Maciej Ceglow, "The Fans Are All Right," Pinboard Blog, October 2, 2011, https://blog.pinboard.in/2011/10/the_fans_are_all_right/

[6] Rebecca Lucy Busker, "Fandom and Male Privilege: Seven Years Later," in "Appropriating, Interpreting, and Transforming Comic Books," ed. Matthew J. Costello, special issue, *Transformative Works and Cultures*, no. 13 (2013), https://doi.org/10.3983/twc.2013.0473

[7] Relatedly, creators of gen fan works have found it easier to go pro. Wattpad (https://www.wattpad.com/) is premised on this.

[8] Constance Penley describes vidding panels at Escapade in NASA/Trek (New York: Verso, 1997), 113–15.

[9] Beth Greenfield, "Sapphic Princess: Dyke Bar Parties Celebrating Xena's Lesbian Subject Are Flourishing All Over Town. A Report from the Trenches," in *HX for Her: The Totally Biased Politically Incorrect Party Paper for Lesbians*, June 4, 1997, scanned at http://www.ausxip.com/articles/1997/hxforher/index.html

weren't shared via song tapes or digitized and put on the Internet. But the fans who came together at Escapade were from many fandoms and so created multifandom structures and institutions that became influential.

All vidding—and indeed all filmmaking—is about getting others to see through the filmmaker's eyes. Slash fans had a particular interpretation of the world that they wanted to literally make visible to spectators, with the goal both of pleasing the converted and converting the uninitiated. According to Sandy Herrold of the Media Cannibals, "Sometimes a vid can be a fight—a fannish fight set to music," where fans argue for particular versions of canon by foregrounding their competing interpretations in their vids. In slash and femslash vidding, these interpretations are often about a character's sexuality. As fellow Cannibal Rachael Sabotini elaborates:

> We have been fighting it out visually and in fiction for—you know, since everything was founded. Since fandom was first kicked out of science fiction fandom. We have vids that present a character's bisexuality . . . because everyone's argued this character is always straight. Well, if you take and synthesize the three minutes of clips of the way he looks at other men, perhaps when you put all three of those three minutes together—set to good music—you come away with the idea that maybe he's not so straight after all.[10]

Successful slash and femslash vidding could make fans see the romantic possibilities of same-sex pairings. More broadly, it was a way of making queer sexuality visible in the world. Sandy Herrold talks passionately about the power of slash vidding:

> The first time I made a *Highlander* vid and showed it to a guy who I had explained about slash to, he was like, "Eh, as if. It's not there. There's no way that you can convince me that they would ever do that." By "they," he admitted later, he meant both of them, both the producers and the characters. Neither of them would do that, whatever *that* is. And then he watched a *Highlander* vid that I had made with the group and said, "Oh my God. Oh my God! I think—Ohhh! You put it in my head! You put it in my head!" And I was like, "Yeah! That's what I'm doing here! I'm putting pictures in your head—they're not even my pictures, but by putting them together in this way I have changed your picture of the whole universe."[11]

The desire to seize the means of production, to subvert the meanings of mainstream television and film for politics and pleasure, obviously has important feminist and queer implications. These were not lost on the fans who congregated at Escapade in the 1990s. The Media Cannibals, a "semi-autonomous Media Fan Collective" based in the progressive Pacific Northwest, chose a rainbow for their credit logo, "because even that point in time [c. 1992], we were about queer awareness."[12] Katherine Scarritt, a longtime fan, con organizer, and vidder who ran the Escapade vid show in the late '90s, is typical of media fans in recognizing the feminist implications of participation in fandom's female art world:

> You know, one thing people with [Camille Bacon-Smith's 1991 book] *Enterprising Women* and all that stuff got right is: this is something particularly about women, and women's feelings and issues and all that. Even though there are some men here and there in the fandom . . . I know one thing Sandy

[10] Interview by Killa and Jarrow of Sandy, Rache, and Gwyn of the Media Cannibals, plus Mlyn for MIT Vidding Documentary, 2007.

[11] Interview by Killa and Jarrow of Sandy, Rache, and Gwyn of the Media Cannibals, plus Mlyn for MIT Vidding Documentary, 2007.

[12] Sandy and Rache of the Media Cannibals, interviewed by Coppa, August 2008.

> [Herrold] has talked about is how she really didn't want men to come to Escapade because women tended to defer to men, and it just ends up as an inhibiting factor. Because we're automatically trained to do that, and especially, any of us, again, over thirty: that is in us, whether we like it or not. I don't want to be that way, but I find myself doing it too, sometimes. And so, if they're looking for the key to it [fandom] or whatever, that's where it's going to be found. But it's women saying things the way they want it to be, not the way they are told it ought to be, even by the women's movement. [13]

Vidding was a chance for women to put their desires on screen without any thought for the male spectator. As Media Cannibal Gwyneth put it, "But what I *really* want to do is direct!" [14]

To direct this way, to use vidding to subvert mass media texts, vidders had to learn the language of television and film. Vid fans got increasingly serious about their art form at Escapade; they began to look at the media as makers, not just spectators. Sandy Herrold says:

> In trying to learn how to tell my story visually, I have learned the visual vocabulary that they use, that I'd never realized was there. So the ability of television and movies to manipulate me visually is still there, I still react to it, but now I notice what they're doing: *oh, this is how they're making this one more important than this one, this is how they're setting things up for us to react to later*. I've learned to notice their language in trying to subvert their language. [15]

Vidders like the Media Cannibals were not just interested in learning the language of film; they also wanted to develop a language for vidding. Because both Charlotte C. Hill and Megan Kent were vidders—Kent in particular was known for vids such as the *Starsky and Hutch* comedy **DON'T USE YOUR PENIS FOR A BRAIN** (1988) (see Video 99 https://doi.org/10.3998/mpub.10069132.cmp.99 and "Spotlight on: Phallic Critique" in the online appendix)—they wanted Escapade to have a formal vid show. Kandy Fong was tapped to run it. The MediaWest vid show had segregated slash from gen and showed slash vids only at night, which was the vidding equivalent of keeping slash zines under the table. But Escapade's vid show was oriented around slash and femslash. Escapade also eliminated MediaWest's vidding contests. There were no competitions at Escapade, other than the contested interpretations of the vids themselves. The first year, Fong curated a show from existing vids, but the next year, the show featured premieres, and for the next decade, Escapade was *the* place to debut new work. Escapade became a meeting ground for the many different cultures of VCR vidding, be they old-school *Star Trek* and *Starsky and Hutch* vidders, the aggrieved slash vidders of MediaWest, literary vidders who'd been inspired by Mary Van Deusen, or members of the San Francisco School. It also created a community for new vidders from all around the United States: the Media Cannibals from the Pacific Northwest, the Chicago Loop, the East Coast Consortium, JAM, Cybel Harper, T'Rhys (notable for being the first known computer vidder), and many others. Vidders asked each other, "What are you bringing to Escapade?"

But Escapade's most important contribution to vidding was arguably the creation of Vid Review, a space given to reviewing and discussing premiering vids modeled on the group critiques of art school. Sandy Herrold claims that this influenced vidding in a way that changed vidding forever, because, as she notes wryly, "That's when we start to talk about vids in large,

[13] Katherine Scarritt, interview at Escapade with Franzeska Dickson for the OTW's Oral History Project, March 7, 2015.

[14] Interview by Killa and Jarrow of Sandy, Rache, and Gwyn of the Media Cannibals, plus Mlyn for MIT Vidding Documentary, 2007.

[15] Interview by Killa and Jarrow of Sandy, Rache, and Gwyn of the Media Cannibals, plus Mlyn for MIT Vidding Documentary, 2007.

painful groups." "Before Escapade," Rachael Sabotini remembers, "you'd go to a con, you'd show your vids, but there was nothing afterwards." Vid Review started off as a postpremiere show vid discussion, except everyone quickly realized that they didn't have the language for a good discussion. As one fan said, "It was like trying to discuss poetry without a common understanding of grammar or spelling."[16] They couldn't even explain why some vids had gone over better than others. Sabotini remembers, "Some people would show their vid and it would not get a good reaction, and other vids would get a *great* reaction. So there was a lot of pissiness about 'Why did your vid get such a great reaction and ours didn't, because ours is better quality and more technically competent than yours is.'" Later vidders might have said that the "quality" vid wasn't received as well in the con setting because it was a living room vid that required great canon familiarity and multiple watches to get all the layers. However, as Herrold points out, "We didn't have the vocabulary to say that. So what were we saying? 'Your vid is too . . . small? Your vid wasn't . . . caught?'" This lack of precise terminology led to arguments—what Herrold describes as "five years of learning to talk about vids in ways that didn't end friendships." Sabotini remembers early Vid Reviews as "incredibly fraught, because one of the things we were interested in was honesty about our reactions to things. And we had people from lots of different disciplines, that were attending . . . but things that were important to one group were not necessarily important to another group, and we fought. Like. Crazy."[17]

Vid Review was where these arguments happened, and where a common language was eventually hammered out. A public critique that went vid by vid, Vid Review soon expanded from one to two hours. It was hosted each year by a different vidder so as to air different perspectives and philosophies. Escapade also began to distribute Vid Comment forms during the premiere show so fans could write down their responses or give anonymous feedback. Panels and roundtables on vidding became part of Escapade's regular programming, as the examples in Box 2 demonstrate.

Box 2. Panels and roundtables on vidding at Escapade.

Panel Title	**Panel Description**
"Song Video Roundtable" (1994), led by Kandy Fong and Deejay Driscoll	"Bring works in progress or finished works you're having difficulty with for a quick jump-start."
"Songvid Editing" (1994), led by Megan Kent and Sandy Herrold	"Authors get edited and usually have to do at least one rewrite of a story. Artists have erasers. What stops songvid makers from doing drafts and re-edits of their work? Let's talk about editing style (what cuts to use for best emphasis) and technique (how to physically do the inserts)."
"Music Video Critique and Workshop" (1996), led by the Media Cannibals	"Roundtable critique of videos, how to tell/recognize story, POV, rhythm. Also, tricks of the trade."
"Con Vids vs. Living Room Vids" (1998), led by Jill and Stacy	"What are the elements that make a music vid accessible to a large crowd, or more appropriate to an intimate setting?

[16] Quoted in "Vid Review," Fanlore, https://fanlore.org/

[17] Francesca Coppa, "Interview with Sandy and Rache ('The Clucking Belles')," *Transformative Works and Cultures*, no. 6 (2011), ¶ 7.2–7.4, https://doi.org/10.3983/twc.2011.0242

The Media Cannibals in particular pushed for these discursive innovations. As a large group themselves, they were used to talking about vids, and they wanted more and better discussion with others. Compared to fanfiction culture, which had, and indeed still has, a strong tradition of writing detailed feedback to authors, vidding was a relative black hole. In the VCR era, vids were either shown at cons, where people might clap with more or less enthusiasm, then move on to the next panel or the bar, or distributed via VHS tapes, which you had no idea if the audience even watched. It was hard to get quality responses. Escapade tried to change that.

By the end of the 1990s, conversation had gotten to a point that discussions could be summarized and codified on handouts or online. Mary Schmidt's "Making Fannish Music Videos" (See Image N. https://doi. org/10.3998/mpub.10069132.cmp.185) came out in its third edition in August 1997, but that was just one of any number of booklets and essays: "Structuring Your Vid: Knowing Your Audience" by Sandy Herrold (1995), "Vidding 101" by Stacy Doyle and Carol Stoneburner (2000), "Creating Mood" by Laura Shapiro (2004), "How to Do Music Videos" by Stacy Doyle, "The Language of Vidding" by here's luck (2004), "The Craft of Vidding" by Killa and Carol S. (2003), "Editing Techniques and Vidding" by P. R. Zed and Carol S. (2004), and "The Life Cycle of Vid and Vidder" by Luminosity (2002). Other meta was posted to the web, like Sandy Herrold's "Don't Touch the 3rd Rail! or Vidding *Suggestions* for Serious Vids" (1999, Box 3).

Box 3. Don't Touch the 3rd Rail! or "Vidding Suggestions for Serious Vids."

On Vidder (*a mailing list for people who make and enjoy songvids*), we've discussed whether vids have a grammar or not; a set of rules that people agree on to make communication easier. Whoo-boy! Not an easy question, and one that evokes a rather emotional response.

After some conversation, we agreed that there aren't a lot of **rules** that make sense in vidding. But we were able to compile a list of techniques that in **serious** vids, tend to be *misused* more often than not.

So, vidding techniques to use sparingly, or think seriously before using:

Blooper reel clips in serious vids

But, it can work if it isn't an obviously 'blooperish' clip or it is the **perfect** clip or the serious song has a more humorous section.

Jump cuts

Can work if the show itself has a fairly jerky style or if you use three or four in a row . . .

Use of credits

But here's some counter-examples. I don't know if any of you have had a chance to see the UK vid . . . I *think* it's called "So Long." It's a vid that says goodbye to the characters of Kes from Voyager and Ivanova from B5 that uses the credits to establish the actors/characters—both clips say "Character as Actor's Name" and then we get a shot of the character disappearing and then we get credit shots of Jeri Ryan as Seven of Nine and Tracy Scoggins as Captain Lochley . . . introducing the replacement characters. I thought this was an excellent use of credits.The Chicago Loop showed a Buffy video recently that used the Buffy credits in an interesting way—I guess it can be done!

Songs with illegible lyrics

But there are some beautiful vids to instrumentals with no lyrics at all . . . Maybe this one should just say, "if your lyrics can't/don't carry the narrative, you'll have to work harder to make sure the clips do."

Black, or fade to black, within the body of the vid

But black can add drama, and fading to black can end a verse or a chorus, or even change POV if it's done very carefully.

Single cuts longer than 8 seconds

Except that once in a while a really long clip is just what you need; what the whole vid has been leading up to.

Clips (with internal cuts) longer than 15–20 seconds

Again, there are rare times when letting the scene run (especially if the camera work in the scene is really well shot) can work.

Unusual versions of well-known songs

Many fans will hate a new version of a song, at least until they've heard it a few times; on the other hand, the new version may give you the gender change you need, or speed up the song enough to be useful, or have much clearer lyrics than the better-known version of the song.

POV changes

They can be very powerful—especially when you're making some sort of compare and contrast of two characters' situation, or their feelings for each other. But, done sloppily or casually, they utterly confuse your audience. (*Personally*, I don't think you can change POV in all songs—you need either a song that has a mood change, or a bridge or in the middle, *or* a song with some strong "I" statements right after the place you want to change, to reorient your audience. *Even more personally*, I think you only get to change POV once—or maybe twice, if the music *really* supported you, perhaps in a duet—and after that, there's almost no chance that the audience will understand what you're trying to say. There are vidders with twice my experience and skill that disagree with me on this one, though.)

These are harder to defend—can someone find examples of these that work?

- Many cuts in a row all the same length (i.e., vary your clip length)
- Many cuts in a row all of head shots (i.e., vary your clip type)
- Doing a whole vid to one show, but including just one clip of the actor from a different show
- Freeze frames
- Speeding up the clip

And this last one isn't really negotiable:

NEVER, EVER, leave any patches of lost signal or gunk between the clips. To quote Methos, "Cut clean."

Vidders now distinguished not just between con vids and living room vids but also between action vids, character studies, comedy vids, constructed reality vids, catharsis vids, ensemble vids, lyric vids, mimic vids, mood vids, narrative vids, persuasive (or argument) vids, recruiter (or promoter) vids, relationship vids, and universe vids.[18] Vidders had learned how cinematic techniques could be used to create a mood; they compiled lists of shots (long shot, medium shot, close-up, two-shot, rack focus, handheld) and kinds of motion (internal vs. external motion; pans, whip pans, pushes and pulls, dolly and zoom shots); they also tried to learn how

[18] These and more were codified by here's luck in her 2004 handout, "The Language of Vidding."

those shots could be deployed to create certain effects (Box 4). Similarly, vidders formulated and disseminated definitions of musical terms: lyrics, mood, tempo, instrumentation, musical movement, verse, chorus, bridge, climax. Whole panels at conventions were devoted to song choice: what makes a good vid song?

These analytical conversations—what fans call meta—also took place on the VIDDER mailing list started by Chicago Loop member tzikeh in July 1997. One hundred vidders and vid fans from all over joined the list, which invited "vidders, vidders-in-training, or vidder-groupies" to "focus on all aspects of vidding, from song choice to technical questions to finding the right clips and anything in between."[19] The list was explicitly for "both slash and gen vidders," and it hosted a few male vidders as well. VIDDER list members debated aesthetics, reported on vid shows they'd seen, swapped tapes with each other, and reviewed them. Together, they confronted the future that was looming: computers and the Internet. "Care to join me on the bleeding edge?" list member Randy Reed asked in a February 1998 post.

> My latest video is available as a real video file at [URL] its 1.8 mb file so it takes about 20 minutes at 28.8 (less at 56k) assuming the server doesn't stall. The video itself is not exactly crystal clear, it plays at a little over 10fps so its not particularly smooth and the song sounds like its being filtered through a tin can. I can solve some of these problems by making the file bigger but my isp will only let my webpage be 2mb so at 1.8 i'm too close to the limit to do more. If someone knew an isp that actually had a real video server that they would license access to cheap, we wouldn't even have to download it.
>
> But whatever you may think of quality issues, i think its good enough that you can see what I'm doing with the vid and give me some feed back. To those of you who despise Jewel a priori I do humbly apologize but I just thought it expressed the angst of Mulder bereft of Scully.

Box 4. Excerpt from "Creating Mood," a handout by Laura Shapiro distributed at Escapade 2004

Cutting Tempo/Clip Length

- Fast (Short Clips)—Hectic, pressure, stress, excitement, unsettling, chaotic, acceleration, rising tension, anger, sexiness
- Slow (Long Clips)—Mellow, relaxed, sadness, romance, sensuality, release, peaceful, thoughtful, denouement

Organizing Shots in a Sequence

- Alternating Close-ups of Two Characters—Intimacy, shared connection, shared emotion
- Moving In—Cutting from a long shot to a medium shot to a close-up creates a sense of focusing in, heightened interest and tension, specificity
- Moving Out—Cutting from a close-up to a medium shot to a long shot creates a sense of distance, space, generalityw
- Jump Cuts—Disorientation, erratic

A more '90s post can hardly be imagined. But online distribution *was* the bleeding edge in the age of dial-up Internet: it took twenty minutes to download a postage-stamp-size video file.[20]

[19] "Vid: The FAQ," reposted to VIDDER mailing list, March 17, 1999.

[20] Later vidders tried sharing vids using early peer-to-peer networks like Kazaa. In the "About Us" section of Headtilt.com, a now-defunct Buffy vidding site, vidder Dr. Dawn teases the other vidders on the site: "You

Reed was also an early proselytizer of digital vidding, putting up an information page on the now- defunct Angelfire web hosting site. DIGITAL VIDEO IS THE FUTURE, it announced. "In the next five years (maybe less) vidding will be done on computers and completely (or at least mostly) digital. Do you want to be left behind?"[21] Vidders most certainly did not want to be left behind, but in this era, vidding on a computer meant building your own system from scratch. Nothing out of the box had enough memory or storage space, or the right capture card. So the VIDDER list became a place to trade information about systems, software, and peripherals, leading to endless threads sharing technical advice.

> Q: I've got a Miro Motion DC20 . . . , but I don't think my drive is fast enough. Where can I find the specs—do I have to open the machine?
>
> A: Depends. <PC advice> If you have a mass-market machine (like a Packard Hell or Compaq), you should be able to find out the specs from documentation that came with your machine. If you had a machine custom-built, then it should say somewhere on the invoice or you could call the place you got it from. Alternately, if you know enough, you can check out what it says when the machine starts and in the bios. </PC advice>
>
> Q: Also, can I purchase an external EIDE?
>
> A: Not as far as I know. However, it's not hard to add a hard drive to your system (if your motherboard supports EIDE). The other option is to add a good SCSI card and get an external SCSI drive, but that's the more expensive route. You can get a good 8.4 gig EIDE drive (Quantum Fireball) for about $350 at the moment, and prices are only going down.[22]

What these vidders are trying to do is to build a computer system that will allow them to capture, digitize, edit, and export their VHS footage. This is what computer vidding was from the mid-1990s to the mid-aughts—the era of dial-up—and it's a distinction that might not be immediately obvious from Randy Reed's information page. Digital video was the future (meaning digital footage via DVD; Internet video distribution is further off), but the present avant-garde thing was computer vidding: the use of hardware and software to import and edit VHS clips on a computer. In 1998, most movies and TV were not yet on DVD, let alone the relatively niche genre television shows—*Blake's 7, The Professionals, Quantum Leap*—beloved by fandom. *Star Trek* was released on DVD from 1999 to 2000, *Starsky and Hutch* from 2004 to 2006. Other shows that fans wanted to vid—*The X-Files*, *Buffy the Vampire Slayer*, *The Sentinel*—were still running and so being taped onto VHS while airing. Cutting-edge vidders used capture devices like the Miro DC20 to digitize their VHS clips, assembled them with software like Media Studio or Premiere, and then exported them back onto VHS for distribution through the usual channels: convention showings or song tapes. Vidding with DVD footage didn't come until later, and sharing video online required the widespread adoption of broadband Internet. Broadband users didn't break 50 percent until 2007.[23]

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two would be nothing without me. You would still be desperately peddling your videos on Kazaa, and sending scary, stalky emails to anyone that uploaded from you." Headtilt, n.d., http://www.headtilt.com/about_us.htm (via the Wayback Machine).

[21] "Digital Vidding on a Budget," http://www.angelfire.com/or/vidding (via the Wayback Machine).

[22] Thread, VIDDER post, June 15, 1998.

[23] "Internet/Broadband Fact Sheet," Pew Research Center, June 12, 2019, http://www.pewinternet.org/fact-sheet/internet-broadband/

While vidding with computers was gathering steam in the late 1990s, the first computer vid that we know of had been made a few years earlier: T'Rhys's **IN THE AIR TONIGHT** (1994). (See Video 37. https://doi. org/10.3998/mpub.10069132.cmp.37) This vid was also notable for being a *Star Trek/Blake's 7* crossover. T'Rhys not only edited using a computer but also used a computer to create effects, so the *Blake's 7* ship, the *Liberator*, appeared on the *Enterprise*'s viewscreen, creating the first blended clips and thus creating an encounter (in this case a hostile one) between characters right in front of our eyes.

The vid was shown at Virgule, a slash con in Seattle. Fans were blown away:

> The best thing happened at the Virgule music vids. I was watching "In the Air Tonight" done for TOS [*Star Trek: The Original Series*], and realizing that the almost slo-mo like jerkiness in the images wasn't a special effect of a video machine, but that it was DIGITIZED, that the images had COME THRU A COMPUTER . . . not video tape to video tape. I was impressed. And then, on the old Enterprise's view screen, right there in space and time, WAS THE LIBERATOR. AND IT MOVED. My heart nearly stopped.

It's perhaps not surprising that this first computer vid was slash; it was in many ways a fanfiction story come to life. Sandy Herrold posted to the VIDDER list: "All of the technical



Fig. 17. The art of montage: Blake fires, Spock is hit.

wizardry was placed in support of a fabulously over-the-top slash narrative: Avon shoots and kills Spock, and Kirk, driven mad through his pain, presses the self-destruct on the Enterprise and kills them all"[24] (Figure 17 https://doi.org/10.3998/ mpub.10069132.cmp.153). Where else were you going to get a story like this? In terms of quality melodrama, it was the best of *Star Trek II: The Wrath of Khan* and *Star Trek III: The Search for Spock* combined. It was the sort of story that fans of genre TV had to make for themselves.

In 1994, In the Air Tonight was considered a rarity and T'Rhys was hailed as a visionary, but by the end of the century, computer vidding was well on its way to disrupting the VHS vidding world. Hardware and software that had only been available to industry professionals was suddenly within the reach of (obsessed, dedicated, technically minded) consumers, so a new generation of vidders—including the many vidders associated with groups such as the WOAD Society, the Chicago Loop, and the East Coast Consortium—went immediately to editing VHS footage via computer, eschewing methods that VCR vidders had collectively hacked into being over two decades. Computer editing software, having been designed for the purpose, easily did all the things that vidders had tortured VCRs into doing. Clean cuts were

[24] Sandy Herrold, quoted in "In the Air Tonight," Fanlore, https://fanlore.org/

no longer difficult, and you could sequence and resequence clips with ease. You no longer had only a few chances at an edit; unlike tape, digitized footage didn't stretch, blur, or break. Moreover, computer editing brought new powers that VCR vidders had only dreamed of. You could change a clip's speed or color, crop the frame, use transitions beyond hard cuts, though the really transformative effects would have to wait until digital footage became standard. There was only so much manipulation that digitized VHS footage would take.

Between the coalescing of aesthetic expertise and the new accessibility of digital editing software, vids suddenly took an enormous aesthetic leap. The late 1990s and early 2000s produced a run of vids at and around Escapade that have become canonical to the community, including many already featured in this book or its online appendix, including Dante's Prayer (Video 5 https://doi.org/10.3998/mpub.10069132. cmp.5), Wouldn't It Be Nice? (Video 9 https://doi.org/10.3998/ mpub.10069132.cmp.9), and Data's Dream (Video 34 https://doi.org/10.3998/mpub.10069132.cmp.34). It's important to note that some of these are VCR vids by VCR vidders working at the top of their game, while others are by computer vidders who are expressing old community aesthetics with new tools. But there was an explosion of energy and creativity all around.

VCR vidders like Katherine Scarritt and Gwyneth Rhys experimented with analog tools like mixing boards to get fades and other effects on VHS. Scarritt took advantage of the coming digital revolution to purchase used analog equipment on what was then a brand-new site: eBay. Scarritt remembers, "Equipment that had previously only been available to professionals, price-wise, was now available on eBay for something reasonable. I was able to buy a mixer, for seven hundred dollars at the time, and it would mix two video streams together."[25] Scarritt used this mixer to make **SCARBOROUGH FAIR** (1997) (Video 38 https://doi. org/10.3998/mpub.10069132.cmp.38), a *Highlander* vid about Duncan McLeod set to Simon and Garfunkle's "Scarborough Fair/Canticle." Scarritt had a specific artistic goal for the vid, noting that the song "is actually two songs that are layered together. And the voices are layered. It's beautifully done. One of them's about war, and one of them's about love. And so I want[ed] to be able to layer the video together about Duncan, war and love, same kind of thing." The mixing board allowed her to do that. However, it had to be done live: you had to have two complete video streams to mix together. "So basically, I had to make one whole vid to the one song, and another whole vid for the other," Scarritt remembers. "And then I played them, and I mixed as I went." The result is a visually textured reading of Duncan's life. As a man who's lived many hundreds of years, Duncan moves through the song's repetitive cycles of impossible love, always in the past tense or, improbably, the future ("she *once was* a true love . . . then *she'll be* a true love "), fighting a never-ending war (soldiers fighting "for a cause they have long ago forgotten"). The vid, which fades dreamily between Duncan's romantic and military narratives, conveys the sense of swirling history that fans loved about the show.

A year later, Gwyneth borrowed Scarritt's mixing board to make her first VCR vid, **THERE'S NO WAY OUT OF HERE** (1998) (Video 39 https:// doi.org/10.3998/mpub.10069132.cmp.39), a vid paralleling the experiences of three heroic female protagonists: Buffy (*Buffy the Vampire Slayer*), *Scully* (*The X-Files*), *and Nikita* (*La Femme Nikita*). Gwyneth introduces each of the characters at the start, then devotes a section of Gilmour's song to each protagonist—three

[25] Katherine Scarritt, interview at Escapade with Franzeska Dickson for the OTW's Oral History Project, March 7, 2015.

repetitions, three heroines—using the numbing, almost trippy repetition of the music to enforce the sense of claustrophobia. She also uses the board to enforce the parallels between the characters using fades and dissolve: "I knew that all three women enter a room in the series pilots and I wanted to start drawing their parallel lines immediately." Like many of the best Media Cannibals vids, There's No Way Out of Here gains power through close analytical observation of the visual text. Rhys herself describes this as "a refinement of something the Cannibals were doing in a way that other vidders weren't then," which was "finding similar shots, similar ideas in different shows, and really bringing them out."[26] Rhys pulls out shots that visually echo each other: "I was inspired by all the parallel imagery to make this: the shots of their own gravestones, coming into mysterious rooms, etc." Stitched together, those shots create a tapestry of female heroism that gives emotional weight to their struggles and angst. The vid was received rapturously at Escapade and has been shown many times since. Like many influential VCR vids, it's been remastered with digital footage and thus dragged forward into the digital age.

But it was computer vidding that was really changing the landscape. Many of the computer vidders who attended Escapade had met in and around *Highlander* fandom, which may explain why they released their vids under the collective banner of the WOAD Society, with "woad" referring to the plant that yields the blue dye that is used to color the warriors' faces in the show. However, the vidders associated with the WOAD Society—which included such influencers as Luminosity, Killa, T. Jonesy, and Carol S., and which later came to include sisabet, Destina, and Melina—vidded in most of the popular fandoms of the day. Their first collection, *It Came from Outer Space* (2002), featured three VHS tapes of vids from *The X-Files*, *Stargate SG-1*, *Star Wars*, *Blake's 7*, and of course *Star Trek* (both Original Series and Next Generation). But computer vidders like these began showing work at Escapade that was truly visual art as well as fannish storytelling and media criticism.

Consider a vid like Carol S.'s **LANGUAGE** (2002, *Stargate SG-1*). (See Video 40. https://doi.org/10.3998/mpub.10069132.cmp.40) The vid was described as "bizarrely experimental" in a review on the VIDDER list: "The source is heavily digitally modified—I have no idea of the technical term for what's been done, but the images end up violently stylized." The images were posturized—that is, processed so that the image consists of distinct, flat areas of color. In addition, Carol S. had a scroll of calligraphic text rise up over the images as the song progressed, creating an aesthetic composition more like a painting than a frame of Hollywood film. (See Image P. https://doi.org/10.3998/mpub.10069132.cmp.187)

In a vid about language and the impossibility of communication, this vid shows as well as tells: language is a tangible thing that stands between us and the images. The text, composed for the vid by another fan named Quinn, begins, "*If I reach for you, will you reach back? Will you meet me halfway, or will you turn your back, walking away? I want to find the words to tell you what you mean to me, what I want to mean to you, but I can't.*" But fans trained to read vids whose every shot carried recognizable context were flummoxed: "The clips are strongly decontextualized. The text that scrolled up the screen was an interesting idea, but I think ultimately I'd have to call it a failure. It was impossible to read—were we supposed to be able to read it? What's the effect of a vid called Language filled with language that cannot be deciphered?"[27] But of

[26] Gywneth, "No Way Out," Dreamwidth, October 3, 2005, https://gwyn.dreamwidth.org/293074.html

[27] Shoshanna, VIDDER post, February 24, 2002.

course that frustration with words is the point of the vid. Similarly, decontextualization is a theme of the song. Suzanne Vega sings, "I'd like to meet you / in a timeless placeless place / Somewhere out of context." But this was a new aesthetic for vidding, which had historically valued visual clarity (partly because quality footage was so hard to obtain) and meanings built out of fandom's shared narrative contexts. Language is not Mary Van Deusen's idea of a literary music video; ironically, Carol S.'s Language is painterly and poetic. In Vid Review, one fan noted that the vid reminded her of Peter Greenaway's *The Pillow Book* (1996), not traditionally thought of as a fannish text.

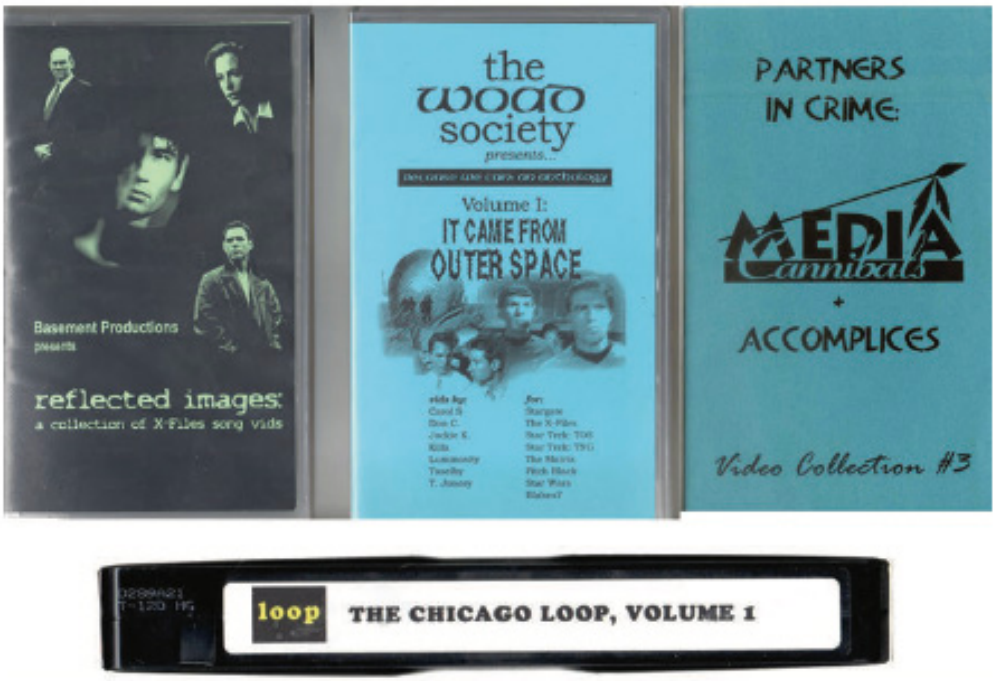


Fig. 18. Branded VHS song tape collections, c. 2000.

Vidding was at this point an art form on full boil. Like the California Crew before them, many of the Escapade vidders had a strong sense of auteurship. This expressed itself not only in the range of work that was getting made—which showed that vidders were only now beginning to see what was possible—but also in credit sequences, song tape boxes, liner notes, T-shirts, and other identarian branding (Figure 18 https:// doi.org/10.3998/mpub.10069132.cmp.154). As tzikeh puts it in her trademark signature line: "VENI, VIDI, VIDDED: I showed up, I watched TV, I made something of it." The bold assertion "I made something of it" was an identity-creating move for the vidder as artist.[28]

Ironically, this explosion of creative energy brought vidders into conflict with Escapade, the convention that had enabled all this development, because not all of the new work was slash, and Escapade was first and foremost a slash con. Where some fans had once said "slash is my fandom," others were now saying "vidding is my fandom." Some were beginning to ask whether Escapade's vid show was fully meeting the needs of its slash-oriented audience.

[28] It also played on *X-Files* creator Chris Carter's logo for Ten Thirteen Productions, in which a child pipes up over the sound of a film reel to declare, "I made this!"

Discussion broke out on the VIDDER list, with Shoshanna Green opening her (pro-vidding) post with "Escapade is not only a great slash con, it's also a great vid con" before going on to discuss the incipient conflict that was brewing:

> There's been some talk, both last year and this, that the Escapade vid show is "too het." I could not disagree more. As I said above, one of the attractions of the con for me is the great vid show, and I don't discriminate among slash, gen, and het vids, the way I do in fiction. . . . I'm just there to see *vids*. Both vidders and non-vidder viewers, in various groupings, have been talking since the con (and probably since before it) about whether a significant number of people (whatever that means) dislike seeing het vids in the show and, if so, whether anything should "be done" about it. My sense is (certainly my hope is) that nobody on the con com is going to ban or even officially discourage "het vids" (how could they even be defined?) [29]

Ironically, among the proposals that had been raised was the creation of a "het ghetto" at Escapade to mirror the segregation of slash vids at MediaWest. In the ensuing discussion, vidders articulated how important Escapade had become to vidding as an art form. LynnC defended the importance of Escapade as a forum for artists regardless of audience: "Vid shows aren't strictly put together as entertainment for the con goers. They are a forum for vidders to show artwork done in the last year—yes, most of the vidders are slashfen, or they wouldn't be there, but art is inspired by many things on the screen, including het relationships. If the audience has expectations that aren't met by the show, the audience needs educating. NOT the vidders." [30] Lynn further elaborated that she went to Escapade "to see the state of the art and what my friends are thinking about." Carol S. also noted the importance of Escapade as a venue for all her vids, slash and otherwise: "The Escapade main show is the only place I *ever* get a wide range of feedback (if you corner your friends and make them watch your vids they are unlikely to be truly negative no matter how they feel). It's not just that Escapade is the only con I consistently attend that has a vid show at all, it's also that the main show at Escapade is the only place that hands out feedback forms." [31]

But not everyone at Escapade wanted an art scene. One VIDDER list member articulated the case for the other side, claiming that vidders had turned Escapade into a captive audience for their artistic explorations. That fan claimed that vidders were taking advantage, ventriloquizing their thoughts as, "I want 100 people in a room to watch this, even though I know better than anyone that it's a vid that most people won't get, and it's not appropriate for this venue"—because it requires multiple rewatches, for instance. The fan asked vidders to consider whether their vids were appropriate for Escapade: "Maybe because it's got major het cooties, or because it's a combo of a very obscure show and very context driven clips and an obscure and inaccessible song." [32] To be fair, the 2001 show had featured thirty-four vids and was three hours long.

Although this explosion of new and experimental vids exhausted some, it energized others—and inspired them to vid. Vividcon founder astolat saw Dante's Prayer at Escapade in 2001 and made her own first vid a month later. Others were similarly inspired, and the 2002 Escapade vid show was, if anything, even stronger. Reviews from that year were gleeful: "Oh

[29] Shoshanna, VIDDER post, February 21, 2001.

[30] LynnC, VIDDER post, February 21, 2001.

[31] Carol S., VIDDER post, February 22, 2001.

[32] Lark, VIDDER post, February 22, 2001.

my GOD, what fantastic vid shows."[33] "It was amazing, and my mind is still awhirl."[34] "Best. Fucking. Show. Ever."[35] Fan and fan critic Eliade attributed the strength of the 2002 show to the impact of computers: "Digital computer vidding is beginning to solidify into the revolution it is—the source for most vids was shockingly clean and the cumulative effect of seeing that much vidding technique just blows me away."[36]

At this point, it was clear that there was enough interest in vidding, not to mention enough vids, to sustain an entire convention. Shortly after the end of Escapade 2002, astolat sent out the first announcement of a new con, Vividcon, to the VIDDER list:

> Vividcon is currently in the planning stages. Our goal is to provide a con dedicated to fannish vidding, for people who like to make vids and people who like to watch them.
>
> Think continuous vid shows throughout the weekend, fandom-specific vid shows, panels to discuss vids, panels on novice and advanced vidding techniques (both for digital and VCR-to-VCR vidding), a try-it-yourself room with vidding systems you can play around with, collaborative vidding sessions, and <insert your idea here>.[37]

Because the new convention was dedicated to vidding itself, all kinds of vids of would be welcome. There would be no more arguments about whether this or that kind of vid was appropriate, as had happened at MediaWest and Escapade. As astolat quickly clarified in response to questions, Vividcon was to be "an equal opportunity con," by which she meant, "We do not discriminate against vids for genre, sexual orientation, fandom, age, technique, or anything else. That means, among other things, that gen, het, slash, and adult (for violence, e.g.) vids are all welcome and will all be given equal opportunity to be shown and discussed."[38]

The first Vividcon was put together quickly and took place in Chicago on August 16–18, 2002. That first con had only two days of programming, though it expanded the next year to three days. However, even at that first Vividcon, a fan could watch an astonishing fifteen hours of vids on a big screen in a theatre setting; as astolat later recollected, "Vividcon was designed to give vid fans a massive fix to hold them for the entire year and to give vidders a great showcase for their vids."[39]

Vividcon: Vivid Constructed Realities

For no reason than anyone can remember, the mascot of Vividcon is a llama with its foot resting on a videocassette.[40] (See Image Q. https:// doi.org/10.3998/mpub.10069132.cmp.188) In fact, the 2002 Vividcon premiere show would be the only one ever released on VHS, which was on its way out; future Vividcon shows were distributed on DVD. But by then, both the llama and its VHS cassette had become iconic. The first Vividcon llama was tinted with rainbow colors to evoke the rainbow noise that had so plagued vidders of the past. In subsequent

[33] Shoshanna, VIDDER post, February 24, 2002.

[34] Laura Shapiro, VIDDER post, February 19, 2002.

[35] Eliade on her blog, February 18, 2001, quoted in "Escapade/Escapade 2002," Fanlore, https://fanlore.org/

[36] Eliade, quoted in "Escapade/Escapade 2002."

[37] Astolat/shalott VIDDER post, February 22, 2002.

[38] Astolat/shalott VIDDER post, February 25, 2002.

[39] Astolat, "About Vividcon," Dreamwidth, June 6, 2017, https://astolat.dreamwidth.org/302253.html

[40] My own peripheral recollection is that the word "llama" was evoked by the abbreviation LLC—that is, a limited liability company, because one was needed to administer the convention.

years, the llama would be dressed to evoke a theme that reflected that year in fandom, with a subtitle to match. For instance, 2003's Pirate!Llama ("Vids Ahoy!") evoked the popular *Pirates of the Caribbean* fandom of that year; 2007 gave us a bespectacled Harry Potter llama ("Accio Vids!"), 2009 a Star Trek llama ("To Boldly Vid!"), and 2014 a Captain America llama ("Even When I Had Nothing, I Had Vids").

The VHS cassette under the llama's foot was only one way in which the history of vidding was evoked by the branding around the con. As I noted in the introduction, the word "vid" was itself embedded in the name "Vividcon," and the limited liability company that astolat and her crew formed to administer the convention was called Vivid Constructed Realities, a name that both alluded to the genre of the "constructed reality" vid and was also easily shortened to VCR.

Vividcon adopted many aspects of vidding practices and culture that had developed at Escapade. This included a Vid Review of the entire premiere show as well as an in-depth review of only one or two vids. Vids were shown in a theatre-like setting, in the dark, without talking or singing. At the 2001 Escapade, the audience had been instructed to sit down and be quiet because the year before, there had been "problems with people talking and walking around during the vids."[41] The next year, vidders addressed the problem creatively by means of an "intro vid." They created a genre of fan video analogous to the short videos that run before the feature at the movies to establish etiquette. Made by tzikeh of the Chicago Loop, Escapade's **INTRO VID 2002** (Video 41 https:// doi.org/10.3998/mpub.10069132.cmp.41) instructed the audience to follow four simple rules: don't talk, don't walk around, don't sing along with the vids, and turn off all cellphones and beepers (yes, beepers were still a thing). These rules applied to all of Vividcon's vid shows. They were enforced not only with a series of increasingly meta intro vids but also through the convention's infrastructure. The first year, the doors to the screening room were locked, with audience members not allowed to enter once the show started or to reenter if they left. When this proved to be too draconian, the con committee rigged the main door with a button that triggered a discreet light manned by a volunteer, who would quickly let people in and out between vids. To make the room as dark as possible, blackout curtains were drawn and the hotel's emergency light bulbs were removed. A surround-sound system was brought into the hotel. All of this is to say that Vividcon took vidding seriously as filmic art and worked hard to create what they considered to be the best atmosphere possible for spectatorship. Vidders responded accordingly and upped their game.

That said, Vividcon also made space for people who wanted (or needed, for disability or other reasons) to view vids differently. An overflow room was set up for premieres that permitted talking and moving around, like at the convention vid shows of old. Vividcon also established a vid library that stocked a large collection of VHS tapes (and later DVDs), which members of the convention could check out and watch in their rooms, just in case fifteen, twenty, or twenty-five hours of theatre-style shows were not enough. The Springhill Suites in Chicago had been chosen partly because each suite had a living area with TV and VHS (later DVD) players, so congoers could have a living room vid experience with friends as well as more formal theatre-style vid viewing. Vividcon also innovated new vid-watching experiences, like Vid Karaoke, a late-night event in which fans, mostly properly lubricated,

[41] Shoshanna, "The Prehistory (and Current Events) of Vividcon," LiveJournal, March 29, 2011, https://the-shoshanna.livejournal.com/335062.html

did karaoke to vids subtitled for the purpose. This allowed singing back into the vid-watching experience, albeit in this highly structured way.

But the chief alternative vid-watching experience was Club Vivid, a dance party during which vids were projected on large screens on both sides of the dance floor. Club Vivid was initially intended simply as fun convention programming—a night of dancing and drinking and canapés set to a curated playlist of danceable vids. But after the first year, the Club Vivid VJs, having learned which vids were good to dance to and which ones weren't, put out a call for new vids to be made specifically for Club Vivid. Club Vivid thus became a space for debuting new work.

As a result, vidders began making what I will call dance vids, which are arguably a different genre than the con vids or living room vids of old. Dance vids are designed to be danced to, so they're particularly rhythmic and fast paced in their cutting as well as in their song choice. Dance vids are also designed to be viewed while the spectator is moving and may also be partly obscured by the crowd of other dancers, so they tend to be particularly colorful and spectacular. In *Keeping Together in Time: Dance and Drill in Human History* (2008), William H. McNeill describes the pleasure humans take in synchronized motion and argues for the importance of dance in creating emotional bonds. In a Club Vivid vid, those pleasures can triple: not only do the clips dance through raccord and rhythmic editing, but characters are made to dance on screen, their choreography emphasized, and the fans dance with them and with each other.

Club Vivid always began with what was essentially a found vid, which fans call The Joxer Dance (2003). (See Video 13. https:// doi.org/10.3998/mpub.10069132.cmp.13) The Joxer Dance is an untouched sequence from *Xena: Warrior Princess* in which the ancient Greek characters perform a hilariously over-the-top rendition of the 1972 pop-rock hit "Dancing in the Moonlight," complete with conga line, as part of an anachronistic "Battle of the Bands." The original idea, according to Melina, who cut the clip, was simply to play the footage as the first "vid" of Club Vivid so as to draw people into the room. The first year, people just watched it and laughed. But afterward, spurred on by vidder F1renze, some fans began trying to learn the sequence's complicated choreography and to perform it along with the characters on screen. Each year, more fans joined in the choreography, but everyone could participate in the conga line, which saw fans snaking around the room and dancing, just as Xena, Gabrielle, and the other characters were doing on screen. The Joxer Dance became a Club Vivid signature event, a happy start to the night. Club Vivid's closing vid, the colorful anime spectacular **STOP THE ROCK** (2003) by Nappy (Video 42 https:// doi.org/10.3998/mpub.10069132.cmp.42), was ritualized into an event as well. It's no accident that the night's final vid is an anime music video. Because it's the last vid after a multihour dance party with an open bar, few people have seen Stop the Rock while sober, which makes it great for a final, sweaty blowout. It's not a story or an interpretation; it's a sensation.

Many of the vids already discussed were made for Club Vivid: A Fannish Taxonomy of Hotness (*Hot Hot Hot*) (Video 20 https://doi. org/10.3998/mpub.10069132.cmp.20), Snakes on a Plane (*Video 10* https://doi.org/10.3998/mpub.10069132.cmp.10), Starships (*Video 31* https://doi.org/10.3998/mpub.10069132.cmp.31). However, notable dance vids also include fan favorites like astolat's **DROP DEAD GORGEOUS** (2003, *Smallville*) (Video 43 https://doi.org/10.3998/mpub.10069132. cmp.43), Dualbunny's God Is a DJ (2006, *Battlestar Galactica*)

(Video 44 https://doi.org/10.3998/mpub.10069132.cmp.44) and **RAISE YOUR GLASS** (2013, *Community*) (Video 45 https://doi.org/10.3998/ mpub.10069132.cmp.45), jarrow's **PAUL MCCARTNEY** (2007, *Will & Grace*) (Video 46 https://doi.org/10.3998/mpub.10069132.cmp.46) and, perhaps most famously, Luminosity's *300* vid **VOGUE** (2007) (Video 47 https://doi.org/10.3998/mpub.10069132.cmp.47), which was recognized by *New York Magazine* and which has had one of the most fascinating afterlives of all vids. (See "Spotlight on: Vogue" in the online appendix.) I justify my designation of "fan favorite" by how immediately and how long the vid stayed in Club Vivid's rotation. Many of these vids were repeated year after year because fans would be disappointed not to see them and dance to them. Several were sequenced into a climatic segment near the party's feverish end.

Most Club Vivid vids literally make their stories or analysis dance: Drop Dead Gorgeous sets its analysis of Clark's Kent's character (he lies about everything, but he's drop dead gorgeous) in the context of shots of Club Zero, a fictional nightclub on the show, and scenes of gyrating bodies; in God Is a DJ, the song tells us that life is a dance floor, and the vidders tells us that *Battlestar Galactica*'s Starbuck dances when she moves, fights, or pilots a spaceship. **A FANNISH TAXONOMY OF HOTNESS (HOT HOT HOT)** constructs a montage that puts characters from a variety of party scenes across television shows onto a single dance floor. "People at the party, hot hot hot!" Buster Poindexter sings, providing the voice of the vidders; the vid takes on new meaning when you realize that it was made for a context in which fans are dancing alongside the characters. Fandom is not just at this giant televisual party; this is *our* party. And in vids like Raise Your Glass and Paul McCartney, vidders continue a tradition that goes all the way back to The Boy Can't Help It: editing comic choreography to emphasize its continuities with dance. In Paul McCartney, jarrow edits footage from *Will & Grace* so that the characters bounce and gyrate, gesticulate, snap, and boogie together.

There is joy in creating and observing these kinds of patterns. As jarrow recollects, "I decided to start by grouping similar clips together (fainting, victorious arm pumps, hugs and kisses, gasping in shock, dances, etc.) and see if I could make sense of it. When I was rewatching the episodes, I grabbed interesting motion-y bits with absolutely no idea that they would be paralleled later (by other characters or themselves). It was such a delightful surprise to end up with something like twenty different clumps of paralleled motion." [42]

If the atmosphere of Club Vivid tends to favor vids with a celebratory aspect, then this celebration is not only of the shows or the characters—though certainly many do celebrate shows and characters. Consider Gwyneth's **BRICK HOUSE** (2010) (Video 48 https://doi.org/10.3998/ mpub.10069132.cmp.48), which asks its spectators to admire magnificent fan-favorite actress Gina Torres. However, many Club Vivid vids have a meta aspect. In vids like **FANNISH TAXONOMY OF HOTNESS**, **GOD IS A DJ**, **RAISE YOUR GLASS**, and **VOGUE**, it's fandom's own creative power that's being celebrated. God is not the DJ here. Fandom is; the vidders are.

In this meta aspect, Club Vivid vids exemplify the vids of Vividcon generally. Many Vividcon vids celebrate vidding or vidding's history. From the first, Vividcon kicked off with a recitation of that history. In 2002, the congoers gathered on the first morning of the convention for a combination vid show/panel called "Retrospective: How on Earth Did We Get

[42] Jarrow, "New Vid: Paul McCartney," LiveJournal, August 15, 2007, https://jarrow.livejournal.com/957773.html

Here?" where one version of vidding history was rehearsed. That first year, tzikeh gave a talk and showed older vids, including **BOTH SIDES NOW** (Video 22 https://doi.org/10.3998/mpub.10069132.cmp.22), **THE ROSE** (Video 25 https://doi.org/10.3998/mpub.10069132.cmp.25), **PRESSURE** (Video 32 https://doi.org/10.3998/mpub.10069132. cmp.32), and **SCARBOROUGH FAIR** (Video 38 https://doi.org/10.3998/ mpub.10069132.cmp.38). That genealogy was itself later made into a vid by Seah & Margie: **WALKING ON THE GROUND** (2005) (Video 30 https:// doi.org/10.3998/mpub.10069132.cmp.30), which tells the story of vidding's evolving technological and cultural practices. (See "Spotlight on: **WALKING ON THE GROUND**" in the online appendix.) In subsequent years, Vividcon's history panel/show was called "The Wayback Machine," "Genealogy of Vidding," or simply "Vidding History," and other moderators rehearsed a variety of subhistories, all of which have informed this book. No other programming was ever scheduled against this annual history lesson. These panels, in conjunction with Vividcon's vid library, demonstrated the con's commitment to establishing an artistic history of the form.

But Vividcon also wanted to be forward looking. Attendees came not only from the vidding communities of the past but also from the new online communities. Vividcon attracted vidders from groups like Nummy Treat (2002), a mailing list dedicated to Buffyverse vids, and from online communities like the Fourth Wall (2007). The con also attracted a few interested anime vidders as the increased visibility of user-generated video online opened doors between the worlds of AMV and live-action vidding. These vidders shared aesthetics and tips in panels with titles like "Topics in Craft: POV," "Timing Is Everything," "The Language of Music," "Typography in Vids," "Literalism vs. Metaphor" and "Curse You, After Effects!" These panels were often paired with vid shows that illustrated the point; other vid shows were curated by theme (for instance, "You're My Best Friend," "End of the World," "Spies Like Us") or technique ("Unreliable Narrators," "Constructed Reality," "No Source? No Problem").

The moment of Vividcon—a moment defined by this combination of artistic cross-pollination, rapidly accelerating technology, and the regular opportunity to present new work—produced an explosion of high-quality vids, with many vidders consciously trying to top themselves from year to year. Many of the vids I discuss in this book were Vividcon premieres. But Vividcon arguably established its own canon. For example, in the 2011 vid show "Ten Years of Vividcon," the moderators chose a premiering vid representing each of the con's first ten years, and chose vids like sisabet's *Farscape* vid **BE SO GLAD** (2006) (Video 49 https://doi. org/10.3998/mpub.10069132.cmp.49), AbsoluteDestiny's *Firefly* and *Serenity* vid **RODEOHEAD** (2007) (Video 50 https://doi.org/10.3998/ mpub.10069132.cmp.50), and hollywoodgrrl's *Fringe* vid **BOOM BOOM POW** (2010) (Video 51 https://doi.org/10.3998/mpub.10069132. cmp.51). This list not only tells you about the vids that were valued within the community but also illustrates the diversification of the vidding community in the aughts. Sisabet came out of online *Buffy* vidding; AbsoluteDestiny is an anime turned live-action vidder; hollywoodgrrl is a multiple winner at the Fourth Wall.

Luminosity and Melina's 2010 intro vid **PREVIOUSLY . . .** (Video 52 https://doi.org/10.3998/mpub.10069132.cmp.52) creates another canon. It is a parody of the "Previously on . . ." voice-overs that bring the viewer up to date on the plot of a serialized television show. The vidders got a male narrator with a broadcaster voice to solemnly intone, "Previously, at the Vividcon Premiere show . . ." to tell you what vids you missed; at the same time, the list

assumes the spectator's familiarity with the twenty-six vids that are name checked or, even more interestingly, only alluded to.

> Previously, at the Vividcon Premiere show: Aeryn and John danced **THE MASOCHISM TANGO** [1], Connor and Murphy were **REBELS OF THE SACRED HEART** [2], Hannibal Lecter was **UNINVITED** [3], Iron Man had no **HANDLEBARS** [4], Frodo and Aragorn Climbed a **MOUNTAIN** [5], *Stargate Atlantis* Built Its City on Rock and Roll [6], Duncan had **TROUBLE WITH POETS [7],** *Farscape* was an **ECSTATIC DRUM TRIP** [8], Jaye had a **BRIGHT FUTURE IN SALES** [9], The Doctor explored **THE MOONS OF JUPITER** [10], Jason Bourne visited a **STREET CAFÉ** [11], Joan Built a **BIG RED BOAT** [12], Skies were Blue for Everyone [13], Starbuck was a **JOKER** [14], Charlie Jade Remembered [15], Faith was a **SUPERSTAR** [16], Kirk had **RAZZLE DAZZLE** [17], Jeremiah went to **WOODSTOCK** [18], Cylons want to **FIX YOU** [19], Girls were **SUPERSMART** [20], Sam Tyler was **CRAZ**Y [21], We Put Giles There [22], War was Hell [23], Astronauts Soared [24], Penguins Marched [25], and then the Earth Exploded [26]! And that's what you missed at Vividcon Premieres.

By the end of this recitation, the allusions are coming fast. "We Put Giles There" at least echoes the title of Laura Shapiro and Lithium Doll's vid, **I PUT YOU THERE** (2006)[43] (Video 122 https://doi.org/10.3998/mpub.10069132.cmp.122), but you have to know that "War was Hell" refers to a comment made about Feochadn's *Band of Brothers* vid, **EBBEN? NE ANDRO LONTANA** (2002). (Video 123 https://doi.org/10.3998/ mpub.10069132.cmp.123). You also have to know in which vids astronauts soared, penguins marched, and the earth exploded. (For the answer to these and other questions, see "Spotlight on: Previously . . ." in the online appendix.) This is not just a canon of vids but a rehearsal of collective experience within a community.

The Collapse of Context

However, even as Vividcon was becoming a hub for vidding, vidding was breaking out of old-school fannish spaces thanks to the digital revolution, Web 2.0, and the Internet. As I noted in the introduction, 2005 marked the thirty-year anniversary of vidding, the third year of Vividcon, and the debut of YouTube. Online video was only made possible by the spread of broadband Internet, which in 2005 was only at 37 percent in the United States, but growing fast. Broadband enabled the development of video streaming sites like Imeem, Blip, Vimeo, Bam Vid Vault, and YouTube, and these sites made user-generated videos like fan vids visible.

The vidders of the early aughts didn't like YouTube. Many of them didn't like the loss of control over one's work that streaming represented, but even those who were willing to trade control for ease of spectatorship preferred Imeem to YouTube. Imeem had social networking features that fans liked, but more importantly, it offered better visual quality and sync. Vidders complained that "YouTube's conversion process throws the video and audio out of sync by a half second,"[44] which might not have mattered to most people but was crazy making to vidders who had timed their videos to the frame. Images were also often pixelated. (Later iterations of YouTube improved both image quality and synchronization.)

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[43] For analyses of I PUT YOU THERE, see Tushnet, "I Put You There"; and Tisha Turk, "Metalepsis in Fan Vids and Fan Fiction," in *Metalepsis in Popular Culture*, ed. Karin Kukkonen and Sonja Klimek (Berlin: De Gruyter, 2011), 213–31.

[44] Comment on "YouTube Opinions," Vidding (LiveJournal community), August 2, 2006, https://vidding.livejournal.com/740102.html

However, the real problem with YouTube was that it created a culture of indiscriminate uploading, which YouTubers framed as sharing but which vidders experienced as theft. One vidder bluntly described "the people on YouTube" as thieves: "Many vidders have had their work stolen, myself included, and put up by users who claim it as their own."[45] This did happen, and sometimes still happens, not only with vids but also with fanfiction and fan art; vidding credits or artists' signatures are cut off, or characters' names are changed. But in addition to outright theft, there was also the problem of—well, fannish behavior. Someone who saw your vid and really, really liked it might feel compelled to share it with the wider public, regardless of whether the vidder wanted that kind of exposure. YouTube made this easy to do.

Typical of vidding history, the clash of cultures started with *Star Trek.* Killa and T. Jonesy's *Star Trek* comedy vid, **KNIGHTS OF THE ROUND TABLE** (2005) (Video 53 https://doi.org/10.3998/mpub.10069132.cmp.53), which closed that year's Vividcon premiere show, went viral on YouTube almost as soon as such a thing was possible. The vid was put up by someone not the vidders in July 2006. A masterpiece of timing and lip synching, Knights of the Round Table was called "the best-edited fanvid ever in the history of YouTube" in 2011, and the claim remains credible today.[46] The *Star Trek* footage is impeccably matched to music from *Monty Python and the Holy Grail*; even the song's opening dialogue ("Look, my liege!" "Camelot!" "Camelot!" "Camelot!" "It's only a model." "Shh!") is matched to the position and affect of the *Star Trek* characters as well as to the movement of their lips. The characters' stylized gestures perfectly match the beats of the song, and while the vid is easily understood and accessible to novice vid watchers, it also provides contextual and canon-based pleasures for harcore fans. For example, for the climactic phrase "I have to push the pram a lot," we see Spock pushing the futuristic wheelchair of previous Enterprise captain Christopher Pike—a meaningful scene for fans.

The self-declared nerds of the Internet went wild for the *Python/Trek* crossover, posting on blogs, lists, and forums urging others to check out this little bit of "geek heaven."[47] The vid even jumped from the Internet to television: I remember seeing a clip from Knights of the Round Table presented as a humorous outro at the end of a local news broadcast in New York City. Some might see this intense attention as success, but as noted previously, vidders at this time feared exposure. They worried that vidding would be seen as piracy and they'd be seen as copyright violators. Killa and T. Jonesy contacted the user who'd put the vid up on YouTube and requested that it be removed. What happened next can be gleaned by reading between the lines of a MetaFilter thread, "I have to push the pram a lot" (July 18, 2006):

> "This video has been removed by the user.": (
>
> —posted by potsmokinghippieoverlord at 1:44 PM on July 19, 2006
>
> Please tell me there's another source! I tried to show the hilarity to someone else, and now it is gone!
>
> —posted by piratebowling at 1:27 PM on July 19, 2006

[45] Comment on "YouTube Opinions."

[46] Rosemary Van Deuren, "Top Ten Funny YouTube Links for Insomniacs," IdlerMag, January 12, 2011, https://idlermag.com/2011/01/12/top-ten-funny-youtube-links-for-insomniacs/

[47] "I have to push the pram a lot!," MetaFilter thread posted by jonson, July 18, 2006, https://www.metafilter.com/53105/I-have-to-push-the-pram-a-lot.

> The Youtube poster says he was asked by the creator to remove the video from YouTube. (*The* Creator . . . ?)
>
> —posted by Snerd at 1:28 PM on July 19, 2006
>
> Is this it listed on this page? Scroll a little over half way down in the page, or search for "Knights of the Round Table" http:// seacouver.slashcity.net/vidland/vids.html
>
> —posted by BillsR100 at 1:23 PM on July 19, 2006
>
> Holy Dilithium Crystals! Check out the other stuff on that creator page—FIFTEEN Trek music video remixes and much MUCH more.
>
> —posted by mwhybark at 1:29 PM on July 19, 2006
>
> That site is going to get hit with the Slashdot effect, but you can't stop the YouTube.
>
> —posted by etoile at 1:28 PM on July 19, 2006

Here we can see, almost in real time, the discovery of vidding by the larger Internet. In searching for "another source," these MetaFilter users discover Killa's own small fannish website, "Vids by Killa and Friends," on which she offers her vids for download to other fans in the old-school manner. "Holy Dilithium Crystals! Check out the other stuff on that creator page," one user yells, driving eyeballs to a fan site that had been made with a smaller, more insular audience in mind.

The MetaFilter fans are aware that driving traffic to Killa's site could have huge negative repercussions for her. The "Slashdot effect" is a sudden and huge increase in traffic, of the kind that would typically bring a website down back in the days when bandwidth caps were small and owners paid out of pocket for web hosting. At this moment of Internet history, before social media, most websites were personal and not ad supported, so there was no upside to getting more clicks or views. Increased traffic, particularly if you were hosting large files like videos, meant only more bandwidth and a bigger bill, which most people couldn't afford. Your site would go down, or a savvy webmaster would quickly take it down to avoid running up costs.

While some sites would try to get back up again as soon as possible, Killa instead chose to take her page down for good, not wanting to expose her fan works to the gaze of outsiders, copyright holders, and network TV stations. But as MetaFilter user etoile predicted, that didn't stop the YouTube: copies of Knights of the Round Table continued to pop up on YouTube, racking up millions of hits. A month later, another of T. Jonesy and Killa's collaborations, **CLOSER** (2003)(Video 54 https://doi.org/10.3998/mpub.10069132.cmp.54), became perhaps the most famous example of a fan vid gone viral and taken out of context. (See "Spotlight on: Closer" in the online appendix.) A slash vid that told a disturbing story of a Vulcan *pon farr*—a mating ritual—gone wrong, Closer garnered intense and baffled admiration from people who didn't really understand what they were seeing. While the vid's editing was admired, many mistook it for parody[48] and left comments like "too funny," "hilarious," "the best spoof . . . that I've seen in a long time," apparently assuming that anything having to do with

[48] For more on this, see Henry Jenkins's analysis of CLOSER, "How to Watch a Fan-Vid," Confessions of an Aca-Fan (blog), September 17, 2006, http://henryjenkins.org/blog/2006/09/how_to_watch_a_fanvid.html

male/male desire ("lol @ gay star trek") or rape ("Vulcan rape lol")[49] must be meant mockingly, as a kind of slam (in the same vein as "George Lucas raped my childhood," or, as Julie Levin Russo argues, homophobic *Brokeback Mountain* parody trailers[50]). Accordingly, most YouTube comments assumed the vidder was male: "Dude knows his Star Trek," "That's the sickest thing I've seen in a while . . . LOL! Good job man," "Dude, ew."[51] The vid got millions of hits and was even brought to the attention of Shatner and Nimoy—not what the vidders intended, and definitely not the vidder's intended audience.

While CLOSER was perhaps the most famous case of a vid wrenched out of context, it was hardly the only one. The years after YouTube's debut saw many vidders complaining about unauthorized uploads as well as worrying about the repercussions of this unintended exposure. In one thread, "Stolen vids on YouTube," vidder StarCrossedGirl discovered that one of her *Star Trek* vids had been put up by multiple users, some claiming it as their own work. When she contacted them, some apologized and took it down, but one replied, in a public comment: "If anyone is a thief on You Tube, it's you StarCrossedGirl! I have a gut feeling that you never thought about breaking copyright laws concerning Star Trek, Jefferson Airplane & Led Zeppelin owners rights. The You Tube executives have been sent and informed of your nasty letter. If any videos are to be taken down, it will be yours! !!"[52] Talk about adding insult to injury! The vidder wondered, would her vids be taken down? Could she get into real trouble? Other vidders had similar experiences—and similar fears: "Don't post at YouTube," "Don't post in the open," "Bottom line—vidders create and host illegal downloads, plain and simple. Don't be stupid about it."[53] Ironically, however, fan vids soon came to typify YouTube's culture of remix and user-generated content, even as they sent individual vidders scurrying for cover, afraid of piracy, bankruptcy, and humiliation.

The Move to Collective Action

But even in this moment of fear and panic, other perspectives began to emerge. Laura Shapiro, an early and influential voice, wrote an essay for the LiveJournal Vidding community called "You Can't Stop the Signal" (December 4, 2006) in which she argued that vidders ought to seize the moment and step into greater public visibility. Shapiro described a vidding community torn between controlling their work and claiming their place in the emerging narrative of remix video. But, Shapiro argued, the moment of control had already passed:

> However legitimate a vidder's fears may be, the fact is that the vids are already out there. The minute we put our vids online, we expose ourselves to the world. We can't stop people from finding and watching vids, especially since the advent of YouTube and similar sites. We can't stop people from

[49] These comments come from the version put up on YouTube by user alexanderadb on September 8, 2006 (https://youtu.be/3uxTpyCdriY).

[50] Julie Levin Russo, "User-Penetrated Content: Fan Video in the Age of Convergence," *Cinema Journal* 48, no. 4 (2009): 125–230.

[51] Comments from alexanderab, "Star Trek + Nine Inch Nails = Closer," YouTube, September 8, 2006, https://youtu.be/3uxTpyCdriY

[52] Starcrossedgirl, "Stolen Vids on YouTube: FUBAR," Vidding (LiveJournal community), October 21, 2008, https://vidding.livejournal.com/1629542.html

[53] Margie, "VVC 2007: Disc Zero—At the Con (1/5)," Dreamwidth, November 16, 2007, https://flummery.dreamwidth.org/2007/11/16/

> sharing our vids without our consent or even our knowledge. We can't control the distribution of our own work in a viral medium.
>
> We also can't control other people's attitudes. New vidders arrive on the scene every day, without any historical context or legal fears, and plunk their vids onto YouTube without a second thought. They post publicly and promote themselves enthusiastically, and why not? That's what everybody does on the Internet, from the AMV creators to machinima makers to Brokeback Mountain parodists to political remixers. All of these works are potentially infringing, but these creators don't hide, and they are drawing attention. Lots of it. Bloggers and news sites are writing about independent media and the rise of user-generated content, and academics are writing books about fannish creations of all kinds. Almost nobody is talking about us yet, but it's only a matter of time. If we aren't there to represent our points of view, what do you think they will say about vidders? [54]

Shapiro's views were no doubt affected by the fact that the month before, she had been asked by Henry Jenkins to participate in the planning of what would become the 2008 24/7 DIY Video Summit at the University of Southern California. Jenkins, then the rare aca-fan who had both attended Escapade and published about vidding, contacted Laura Shapiro so that she could bring the perspective of live-action vidders to the table. The 24/7 DIY festival, put together by Steve Anderson and Mimi Ito, was intended "to bring together DIY video creators, activists, policymakers, Internet companies, and media industries to celebrate new forms of creative practice, debate competing visions of the future, and craft shared agenda." [55] Shapiro, a vidder from the tech-central Bay Area and a political activist, was intrigued by the conference's goals, which included bringing digital video communities together and creating alliances between them. She joined the 24/7 DIY Video Summit planning committee and began to publicize the festival to vidders.

These and other issues were pressing enough that Vividcon 2007 organized a Town Hall on Vidding and Visibility to discuss these questions within the community—or at least as much of it as could be gotten together in person at one time. Almost all of the convention's 150 or so members crowded into the main panel room to discuss the "question of should vidding be more or less visible, and how do we control it, assuming we can or should control it." [56] Various postconvention reports summarized the discussion, which turned into a debate about personal privacy versus normalizing fan works, particularly women's fan works. Vidders shared stories about engaging the broader world outside of fandom. For example, Luminosity described showing vids at 2003's Slayage, an academic *Buffy the Vampire Slayer* convention, and getting only condescension in the panel that followed, with one male scholar referring to "your little movies" and a woman academic asking where the male vidders were, implying that if men weren't doing it, it was only a hobby, not art. Another example: Jackie K. Jono discussed an interaction she'd had on the academic media site In Media Res, where a male media critic had uploaded a fan vid as a prompt for discussion, which he described as "a generic YouTube redaction of scenes from *Bleak House* under a soundtrack of Andain's 'Beautiful Things,' a song apparently about teenage suicide. It is classic DIY self-made creative content, using television (without regard to IP law) to produce a personal 'trance' or reverie

[54] Laura Shapiro, "Vidding Meta: You Can't Stop the Signal," Vidding (LiveJournal community), December 4, 2006, https://vidding.livejournal.com/893694.html

[55] Laura Shapiro, "Representing Vidding to the Wider World: Suggestions Needed," Vidding (LiveJournal community), April 8, 2007, https://vidding.livejournal.com/1035085.html

[56] Margie, "VVC 2007."

about *watching television with thoughts in your head*."[57] The critic thought that the vid had failed to explicate the source text's Marxist critique, but Jono took offense at the critic's dismissive tone. Replying "I am a vidder," Jono explained in a comment what she thought the vid was doing and why it might matter:

> The vidder has taken this story and pulled out of it a theme I find more interesting. She is exploring what it means to be beautiful in the context of this society. The woman who is the main character of the vid has a beautiful soul but has been disfigured by smallpox. The social status of women in this world is based primarily on their appearance and the context of their character is completely irrelevant. That theme goes right to the heart of the psychological, social, and philosophical issues of self worth, jealousy, and identity that I have to deal with every day The fact that the vidder chose to focus on that theme rather than the more directly economic one that is central to the story is, in a way, quite political.[58]

Jono concluded: "Fan fiction and fan vids have a very long history. Historically, they have been made by women for other women about stuff women tend to like and men often scoff at." Jono told the Town Hall that she had felt compelled to defend this random vid, which had been pulled from YouTube and made by a fan she didn't know.

Vidders SDWolfpup and Rowena discovered that their vids, respectively **COIN OPERATED BOY** (2004) (Video 55 https://doi.org/10.3998/ mpub.10069132.cmp.55) and **BUFFY, ABRIDGED** (2004) (Video 56 https://doi.org/10.3998/mpub.10069132.cmp.56), were being shown in theatres around the United States as part of the sing-along screenings of *Buffy the Vampire Slayer*'s musical episode, "Once More, With Feeling." The sing-along people had gotten permission from Fox, the program's owner, to show the episode in theatres (though Fox revoked those permissions a year later), but nobody asked the vidders for permission to show their work as part of the entertainment, though *Buffy* creator Joss Whedon had posted a "shout-out to our video making peeps" on the Whedonesque blog after attending a showing of the sing-along in Los Angeles.[59]

Laura Shapiro told the room about the coming 24/7 DIY Video Summit, and I told the story I told at the start of this book: that I had attended Signal/Noise 2k5: Creative Revolution at Harvard with fellow fans Naomi Novik and Rebecca Tushnet, only to hear that people started making cool remix videos in the '90s. Six months before Vividcon's Town Hall, in December 2006, *Time* had decided that You—the You who makes videos for YouTube—was the person of the year. Now vidders at the Town Hall asked each other, "Are we Time Magazine's 'Person of the Year' or are we criminals?"[60]

After listening and talking, fandom came to a number of conclusions: "People are finding us whether we want it or not. We can't hide in plain sight anymore. We could choose to require passwords again, or we could explain." The suggestion was made that "those who can afford to be public about their involvement in vidding, *and who are willing to take that step*, should do what they can to be a normalizing presence in the world, whether that be publish-

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[57] John Hartley, "Bleak House—Beautiful Things," In Media Res, November 17, 2007, http://mediacommons.org/imr/2006/11/17/bleak-house-beautiful-things

[58] Jackie K. Jono, comment to Hartley, "Bleak House—Beautiful Things."

[59] Joss Whedon, "Me Links to Me," June 30, 2007, Whedonesque, http://whedonesque.com/comments/13590

[60] Par Avion, "Panel Notes from VVC 2007 Town Hall on Vidding and Visibility, August 16, 2007," Vividcon (LiveJournal community), https://vividcon.livejournal.com/119137.html

ing academically, or talking about one's vids at work or at home, or whatever else people might be comfortable doing. Those who can't afford to be public can be supportive in other ways."[61] Vidders' decision to raise their profile—to normalize, to explain, to be "out" as a vidder if you could be—aligned with decisions that were being made in other parts of fandom. Naomi Novik, Rebecca Tushnet, and I, along with seventy other volunteers, had founded the nonprofit Organization for Transformative Works three months earlier, in May 2007. The OTW was also dedicated to creating a fan-controlled, public-facing side of fandom. Its very name articulated and promulgated a legal theory of fan works: that they are transformative, and thus a fair use of copyrighted material. The women who built the OTW feared that unless grassroots fandom became more visible, venture capitalists would create the front doors that new fans would walk through—and then buy and sell fans and fandom as a product. People were still joining the Internet in droves. When new fans searched online for "Buffy fanfiction" or "Star Trek vids" what would they find? What sites would they be sent to?

As I write this, we're more aware of the damaging effects of commercial social media: Cambridge Analytica hacking Facebook, Russian bots on Twitter, YouTube's algorithms steering spectators to ever more extreme videos, including those of white supremacists, to boost "engagement." But the fan communities that I come from, which included many early adopters of technology and scientifically minded women, were worried about the damaging effects of capitalism on their online networks almost as soon as social media arrived. It wasn't just prescience, though fans were indeed prescient; it was also that they were more fully online than most people and thus able to witness negative effects as they happened. Many Web 2.0 startups wrote terms of service (TOS) that clearly or implicitly excluded fans. Other social networks seemed more fan friendly, but then they would be sold—or more precisely, they would sell their large "user base" of "highly engaged content creators" (aka fans) for huge amounts of money, whereupon, like as not, the new owners would rewrite the TOS. (Fans, like other early Internet denizens, had a fear of being TOSed, or removed for violating the terms of service.) Each time that happened, fandom's network would be disrupted and its fan works—fanfiction, art, vids—put at risk.

The OTW was an attempt to take some control in that Wild West environment. Fans wanted a stable environment, a homestead. There was a lot of focus in the early OTW on ownership. Fans wanted to own the servers that housed their works; they wanted to own the means of production when it came to making fan works; they wanted their labor to benefit them, not some venture capitalist who wanted to scoop them up cheap and sell them or their data at a profit. In this spirit, the OTW's flagship project was called the Archive of Our Own (AO3), invoking both a Marxist ownership of the means of production and Virginia Woolf's dictum that "A woman must have money and a room of her own if she is to write fiction." The OTW also launched an academic journal (*Transformative Works and Cultures*), a community wiki (Fanlore), and a project for rescuing at-risk fan works, including analog works like zines and VHS vids (Open Doors). The OTW also launched a legal advocacy project and a vidding committee (later renamed "fan video and multimedia"). Many of the attendees of the 2007 Vividcon Town Hall on Vidding and Visibility were already involved with the nascent OTW, but more got involved afterward. Other vidders chose different forms of advocacy.

[61] Margie, "VVC 2007."

The vidders who had chosen visibility went at it with gusto. To the surprise of the organizers, a bloc of vidders showed up at the 24/7 DIY Video Summit, revealing themselves to be more highly organized (and more opinionated) than video makers in other genres. As the first chair of the OTW's vidding committee, I collaborated with Laura Shapiro on the 24/7 DIY showcase and gave a talk drawn from Vividcon's many history panels. (Notably, I was one of only three female speakers out of seventeen; remix culture was still heavily male dominated.) The summit was hugely influential, creating connections that later produced many positive outcomes, as I discuss below. The vidders who attended intermingled with other online video creators—AMV makers, political remixers, vloggers, machinima creators, activist media makers, and documentarians—as well as with media activists and scholars like Lawrence Lessig, Yochai Benkler, Henry Jenkins, Howard Rheingold, Michael Wesch, and John Seeley Brown. They also engaged policy makers from institutions like the Electronic Frontier Foundation (EFF), Critical Commons, and the Participatory Culture Foundation. Laura Shapiro and I filmed interviews with many of the vidders who attend the summit, and we used these and other interviews to make *Vidding (2008)*,[62] a series of short videos for MIT's New Media Literacies project.[63] Topics included "What is Vidding?" (1:28), "Technology and Tools" (1:29), "Good Vids, Bad Vids" (1:28), "I Like to Watch" (1:29), "Collaboration and Community" (1:23), and "Why We Vid" (1:20).

OTW's communications team also became a hub for public relations and journalistic inquiry about fandom, giving quotes to journalists or connecting them to knowledgeable sources or people to interview. In 2007, Luminosity's Vogue (Video 47 https://doi.org/10.3998/mpub.10069132.cmp.47) went viral and was picked by New York Magazine as one of "The Twenty (Intentionally) Funniest Web Videos of 2007."[64] This time, however, the aftermath of exposure was very different. Luminosity contacted the OTW, who helped her negotiate inquiries from the press. The result was "The Vidder," by Logan Hill,[65] a profile of Luminosity that, according to Henry Jenkins, "is respectful of her accomplishments and seeks to reclaim a place for women's creative work in the larger history of online video."[66] It begins, "Luminosity is the best fan that shows like *Friday Night Lights*, *Highlander*, *Farscape*, and *Buffy* ever had—but she can't use her real name in this interview for fear that their producers will sue her. As a vidder—a director of passionate tributes and critiques of her favorite shows—Luminosity samples video in order to remix and reinterpret it, bending source material to her own purposes."[67] Rather than treat Luminosity as someone doing something weird or laughable, Hill asked her about her body of work and her visual influences.[68] Luminosity

[62] See "Vidding," Organization for Transformative Works, https://www.transformativeworks.org/vidding-index/vidding_en/; and the ProjectNML YouTube channel Fanvidding, at https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=2xCUw_M_U30

[63] See also Henry Jenkins, "Fan Vidding: A Labor of Love (Part One)," Confessions of an Aca-Fan (blog), December 5, 2008, http://henryjenkins.org/2008/12/fanvidding.html

[64] "The Twenty (Intentionally) Funniest Web Videos of 2007," *New York Magazine*, November 8, 2007, https://nymag.com/movies/features/videos/40663/index1.html.

[65] Logan Hill, "The Vidder," *New York Magazine*, November 8, 2007, http://nymag.com/movies/features/videos/40622/

[66] Henry Jenkins, "Vidder Luminosity Profiled in *New York Magazine*," Confessions of an Aca-Fan (blog), November 20, 2007, http://henryjenkins.org/2007/11/vidder_luminosity_profiled_in.html

[67] Hill, "Vidder."

[68] Luminosity's answer: "My favorites were the film noir directors of the forties and fifties—Orson Welles,

was subsequently asked by the magazine to judge "The Best Fan Vids of 2008": "Last year, we raved about underground fan vidder Luminosity's brilliant video riffs on *300* and *Supernatural*. So this year, we asked *her* to pick the best fan vids of the year. 'Vidders are becoming more comfortable with their tech, which allows some daring creativity, and it really shows,' says Luminosity, who doesn't use her real name owing to copyright issues." [69] Luminosity was also asked to be one of the judges of Total Recut's video remix challenge of 2008; other judges that year included media scholars and fair use advocates such as Lawrence Lessig, Henry Jenkins, Patricia Aufderheide, J. D. Lasica, Kembrew McLeod, and Mark Hosler—an excellent group, but again, note the skewed gender breakdown. Still, this was a marked difference from Killa and T. Jonesy's experience of going viral in 2006.

The vidding activism of this period culminated with the successful campaign to get a Digital Millennium Copyright Act exemption for non-commercial remixers like vidders. The DMCA posed a legal obstacle to vidders in that it protected DVD encryption technology and made the breaking of those encryptions illegal; in other words, even though it was technologically possible to do so, it was illegal for vidders to rip their own, legally purchased DVDs to get source clips for vidding. The prohibition against ripping was meant to prevent piracy, not remix; legal scholar Rebecca Tushnet often uses the metaphor of fans as dolphins caught in nets meant for tuna. For vidders, DMCA's prohibition of decryption was particularly bitter in that they believed that the vids they were making were textbook fair use: vids are non-commercial, they use only short clips, and they're transformative in meaning and message, creating new interpretations and making analytical arguments. Whether as transformative art or protected speech, vidding ought to be a fair use. But because ripping DVDs was prohibited by the DMCA, vidders, like other remixers, were guilty on a technicality before they could even argue. As Michael Wesch explained in his "anthropological introduction to YouTube," "The simple act of ripping a DVD is actually illegal, which makes virtually everything we do illegal." [70]

The proposal for a DMCA exemption aligned vidders with other remix artists as well as with documentary filmmakers, who also wanted to incorporate short clips into their work. A coalition formed, with many of the key players having met at the 24/7 DIY Video Summit. The EFF proposed the exemption to the Library of Congress, and the OTW submitted a reply comment in support. The OTW also marshaled exhibits and testimony specific to vidding, both live at the open hearings and in writing. Vidders testified about vidding as a practice and about the ways they had been adversely affected by the DMCA. I talked about vidding history and rehearsed many of the arguments of this book. Vidder and vid scholar Tisha Turk gave more practical testimony, explaining why the Motion Picture Association of America (MPAA)'s remedy for remixers—getting clips by filming their screens with a camcorder (which ironically doesn't violate the DMCA)—wouldn't work for vidders, who need high-quality, information-dense images that can be manipulated without degradation.

Jacques Tourneur. On TV, I admire David Nutter, Kim and Kelly Manners, and Joss Whedon." Hill, "Vidder."

[69] Logan Hill, "The Best Fan Vids of 2008," Vulture, November 25, 2008, https://www.vulture.com/2008/11/best_fan_vids_of_2008_1.html

[70] Michael Wesch, "An Anthropological Introduction to YouTube," presented at the Library of Congress, June 23, 2008, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=TPAO-lZ4_hU

The OTW also created and posted an online Test Suite of Fair Use Vids, a group of contextualized vids offered in support of arguments like the following:

> Vidding is a legitimate artistic and culturally valuable pursuit that represents an established and growing community.
>
> Vidding promotes both technical ability and creativity. Vids are forms of legitimate cultural criticism.
>
> Vids propose alternate readings and realities.[71]

The original Test Suite comprised four vids: Luminosity and sisabet's **WOMEN'S WORK** (2007) (Video 57 https://doi.org/10.3998/ mpub.10069132.cmp.57), lim's **THIS IS HOW IT WORKS** (2006) (Video 58 https://doi.org/10.3998/mpub.10069132.cmp.58), **HANDLEBARS** (2008) (Video 59 https://doi.org/10.3998/mpub.10069132.cmp.59) by Seah & Margie, and Closer, by T. Jonesy and Killa (Video 54 https://doi. org/10.3998/mpub.10069132.cmp.54). (See "Spotlight on: The OTW's Test Suite of Fair Use Vids" in the online appendix.) It was expanded in 2012 to include The Price by thingswithwings (discussed in the introduction), **PIECE OF ME** (2008) (Video 60 https://doi.org/10.3998/ mpub.10069132.cmp.60) by Obsessive24, **IT DEPENDS ON WHAT YOU PAY** (2009) (Video 61 https://doi.org/10.3998/mpub.10069132.cmp.61) by Gianduja Kiss, **"WHITE" AND NERDY** (2009) (Video 62 https://doi. org/10.3998/mpub.10069132.cmp.62) by talitha78, **THE TEST** (2010) (Video 63 https://doi.org/10.3998/mpub.10069132.cmp.63) by here's luck, and also **BUFFY VS. EDWARD** (2009), a non-musical *Buffy/Twilight* remix video by political remixer Jonathan McIntosh in which the feminist Buffy meets, rejects, and then kills Edward Cullen, *Twilight*'s stalkery vampire. In making Buffy vs. Edward, McIntosh "was influenced by vidding and vidders like Laura Shapiro."[72] Political remixers and vidders had begun to intermingle and exchange ideas in the wake of the 24/7 DIY Video Summit.

The DMCA exemption for noncommercial remixers was granted in 2009 (and was renewed and expanded in 2012, 2015, and 2018. The 2021 renewal is in process as this book goes to press). "We won!" Turk crowed in her LiveJournal. "I am so happy, and also possibly a little overwhelmed." She added in a comment: "I have to say, the vidders in the OTW test suite are my superheroes; their work is cited all over the Register's recommendations. Vidders make art; once we made the copyright office look closely at that art and understand how and why it gets made, they had to acknowledge that the DMCA was restricting fair uses of copyrighted material."[73] This was true. In the recommendation, the register of copyrights recognized vidding as an art and understood and accepted the arguments about what vidders need to make them: "Noncommercial, transformative users have also sufficiently demonstrated that certain uses require high quality in order for the purpose of the use to be sufficiently expressed and communicated. For instance, where focus on background material in a motion picture

[71] Organization for Transformative Works, "Test Suite of Fair Use Vids," https://www.transformativeworks.org/legal/vidtestsuite/

[72] "Buffy v. Edward: Twilight Remixed," by Jonathan McIntosh, June 20, 2009, http://popculturedetective.agency/2009/buffy-vs-edward-twilight-remixed

[73] Tisha Turk, "DMCA Exemption for Noncommercial Remix Video!," LiveJournal, July 26, 2010, https://tishaturk.livejournal.com/7355.html

is essential to the transformative purpose, as exemplified in the situation of bringing the background to the foreground, the use of decrypted DVDs is necessary to make the point."[74]

The register cited as an example Lierdumoa's **HOW MUCH IS THAT GEISHA IN THE WINDOW** (2008) (Video 64 https://doi.org/10.3998/ mpub.10069132.cmp.64), a vid that was made in order to construct an absence—that is, to show how few Asian characters exist in a show, *Firefly*, that ostensibly describes a future in which the United States and China now form a single superpower. All of the characters can and often do speak Chinese, but, as the register noted, "the vid demonstrates that almost no Asian characters are featured and that they appear only in the background. The vid concludes with a text screen that states: 'There is only one Asian actor with English dialogue in all of *Firefly'* and in the next screen states, 'She plays a whore.'"[75] This was understood as a transformative use, and the register further understood Lierdumoa's focus on the background of the show meant that she needed high-quality footage, concluding that "if a transformative user begins with a work of degraded quality, the further degradation that will likely occur in rendering the work to the public can completely obscure the purpose of the use." The register then rehearsed others examples from vidding:

> For instance, Women's Work, by Luminosity and sisabet, assembles short clips from the television series *Supernatural* depicting images of women who are "shown only as eroticized, suffering or demonized." In a number of the clips, the images are difficult to see and had this video been made using pixilated video capture, it is reasonably likely that the point of many scenes' inclusion would not be perceptible. Several vids cited in the record reveal that extensive editing is often performed on the clips reproduced from motion pictures. For instance, in Luminosity's Vogue (using clips from the motion picture *300* to cast the violence in scenes from the movie in an aesthetically modified manner), not only are clips often rendered side-by-side and synchronized, but there is also color and timing modification of the clips used. Other vids also modify the original clips and images, saturating them with color and morphing images into others. For instance, lim's This Is How It Works (using clips from the series *Stargate: Atlantis*) and Us (with clips from a long list of movies) both morph and colorize clips to serve the messages of the vids. Although some vids cited do not significantly alter the actual images, the pace of the clips or the focus on a particular part of the clip by the vidder tend to demand clarity of the clips in order to perceive the purpose for inclusion. For instance, in Closer, by T. Jonesy and Killa, the vidders present an alternative interpretation of an episode from *Star Trek* in order to hypothesize about the relationship between Captain Kirk and Spock. In Handlebars, by Seah and Margie, the vidders examine the Doctor character in the series *Dr. Who* [sic], extracting a multitude of short clips from the series to demonstrate the development of the character while also choosing scenes that fit the lyrics of the song that accompanies the clips. In the course of the character development, the vidders begin whimsically, and then reveal how the smaller exercises of power lead to violence and destruction at the Doctor's hands. This vid criticizes the "moral blind spots by recontextualizing events viewers have already seen." Although some may question the significance of the comment or criticism at issue in these vids, some comment or criticism is involved that either requires or significantly benefits from the use of high quality reproductions of the clips from motion pictures.[76]

This validation was heady; in fact, this entire period of organization, visibility, and activism was exciting. In a very short period, vidders went from being completely underground

[74] Marybeth Peters, "Recommendation of the Register of Copyrights," Copyright.gov, June 11, 2010, 66.

[75] Peters, "Recommendation," 66.

[76] Peters, "Recommendation," 66–68.

artists to being profiled in national publications and formally recognized by the Library of Congress. "We are amazing and enormous—more than we realize," one vidder said at the Town Hall. "We have secret strengths as a community that we don't know about because we hide."[77] Now that vidding had come out of hiding, vidders felt suddenly energized, powerful, jubilant.

Being vidders, of course they vidded it. In the midst of what felt like a movement, Counteragent made **DESTINY CALLING: A TRIBUTE TO VIDDING** (2008) (Video 65 https://doi.org/10.3998/mpub.10069132.cmp.65) for More Joy Day, an annual online festival dedicated to spreading joy. "I was giddy with the flush of infatuation with the craft, the vids, and the vidders," Counteragent later told Henry Jenkins. "I was shouting my love from the mountaintops.[78] A metavid made from other (properly credited) vids, Destiny Calling has the same swelling pride as the Oscars montage of the year's best films. It is a joyful boast, a triumphant showing off of the art.

"So we may be gorgeous / So we may be famous," the song begins, cutting to instantly recognizable shots from lim's Us and Luminosity's Vogue before going on to name check and celebrate a host of other vids. The song's chorus runs, "This is our destiny calling / We're freaks / Unique / This is our destiny calling now," which nicely encapsulates both vidding's heroic public triumphs and the residual sense of being part of a freakish geek culture. In "Nothing

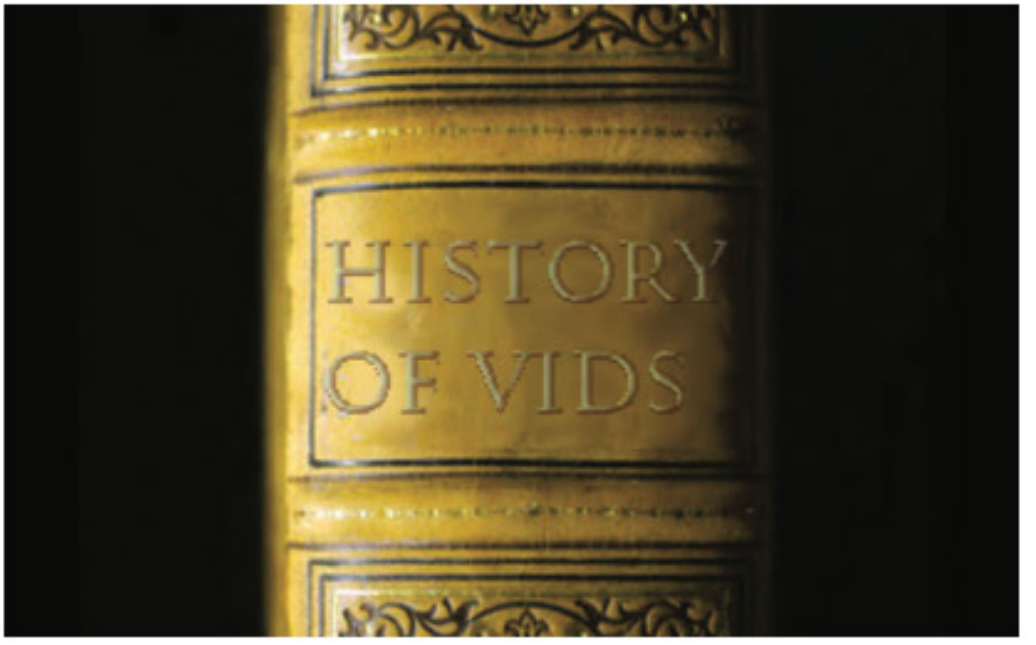


Fig. 19. History of vids from Counteragent's DESTINY CALLING: A TRIBUTE TO VIDDING (2008).

but Net: When Cultures Collide," Cathy Cupitt describes Destiny Calling as "a snapshot of the fannish zeitgeist of that moment," noting that it not only alludes to the formation of "a

[77] Par Avion, "Panel Notes from VVC 2007."

[78] Henry Jenkins, "DIY Media 2010: Fan Vids (Part Four)," Confessions of An Aca-Fan (blog), November 30, 2010, http://henryjenkins.org/blog/2010/12/diy_media_2010_fan_vids_part_f.html

recognizable canon" but also references current events in vidding culture.[79] In Destiny Calling, Counteragent includes shots of Luminosity's *New York Magazine* profile, OTW's website, video editing software, and vids on YouTube. She also imagines a leather-bound History of Vids on the shelf of a library (leather-bound *History of Vids on the shelf of a library* (Figure 19 https://doi.org/10.3998/ mpub.10069132.cmp.155)—a book very like this one.

[79] Cathy Cupitt, "Nothing but Net: When Cultures Collide," *Transformative Works and Cultures*, no. 1 (2008), https://doi.org/10.3983/twc.2008.055